

Brief

Aberdeen Cultural Foundry



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This brief document has been prepared by Daria Shiryaeva as part of the Master of Architecture degree at the University of Bath, Department of Architecture and Civil Engineering. It is intended to be read in conjunction with the wider masterplan for Aberdeen Harbour, which explores the city's transition from an industrial, oil-based economy toward a more cultural and publicly accessible waterfront.

The brief sets out the conceptual, spatial, and technical framework for an individual architectural proposal within this context.

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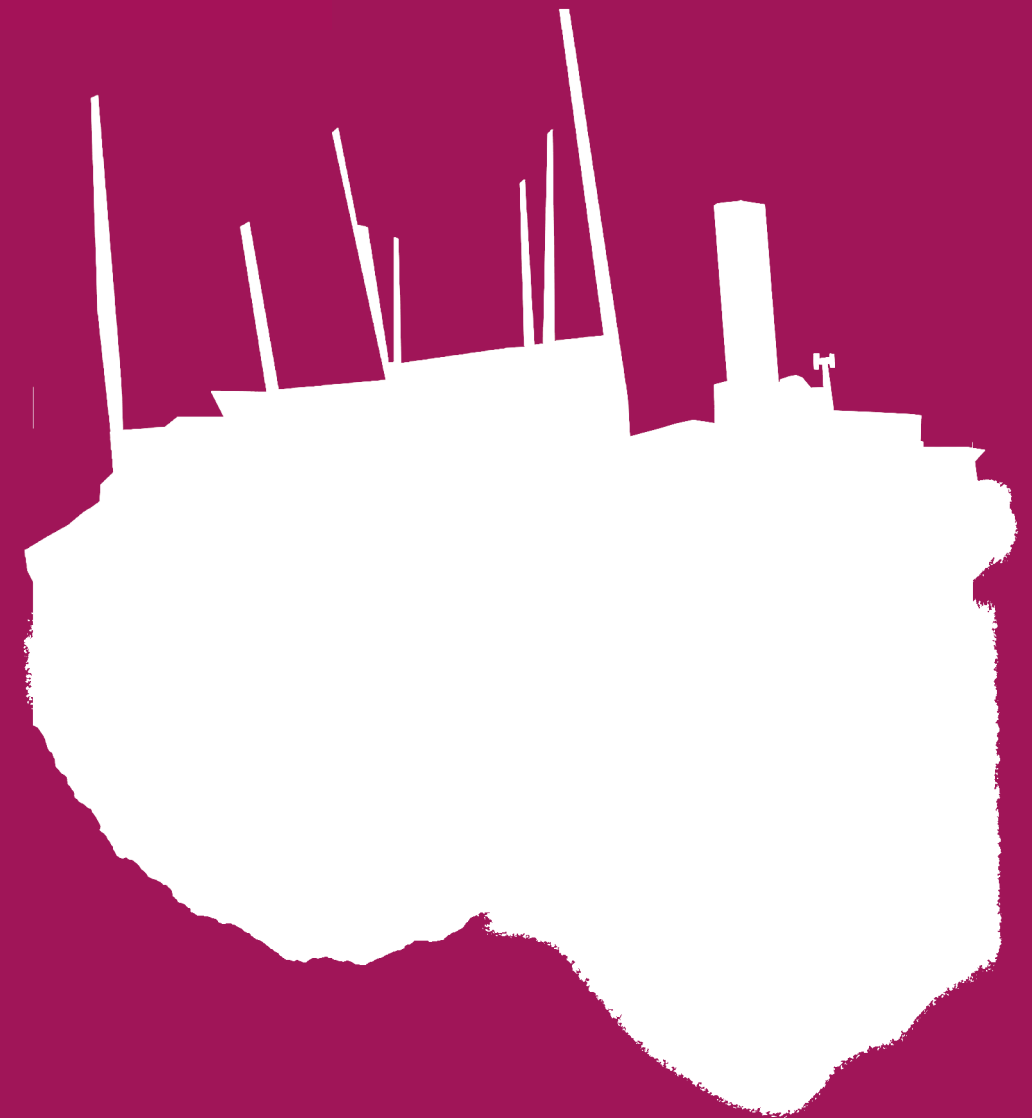
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Architectural Agenda

Aberdeen's harbour has long been shaped by extraction, industry, and restricted access, defining the city's relationship with the North Sea. As industrial activity shifts to the South Harbour, the historic waterfront enters a moment of transition, opening up new civic and cultural possibilities.

Situated between land and water, industry and city, the site becomes a threshold condition. This brief proposes a cultural and production-led building that reclaims the harbour as a place where art production and public life intersect. Studios and galleries are conceived as open and interconnected spaces, allowing creative processes to become visible and embedded within the public realm.

Rather than erasing the harbour's industrial legacy, the project works with it critically through material reuse, landscape integration, and spatial openness. In doing so, the architecture positions culture as a form of civic infrastructure, supporting Aberdeen's transition toward a more inclusive, publicly engaged, and sustainable waterfront.

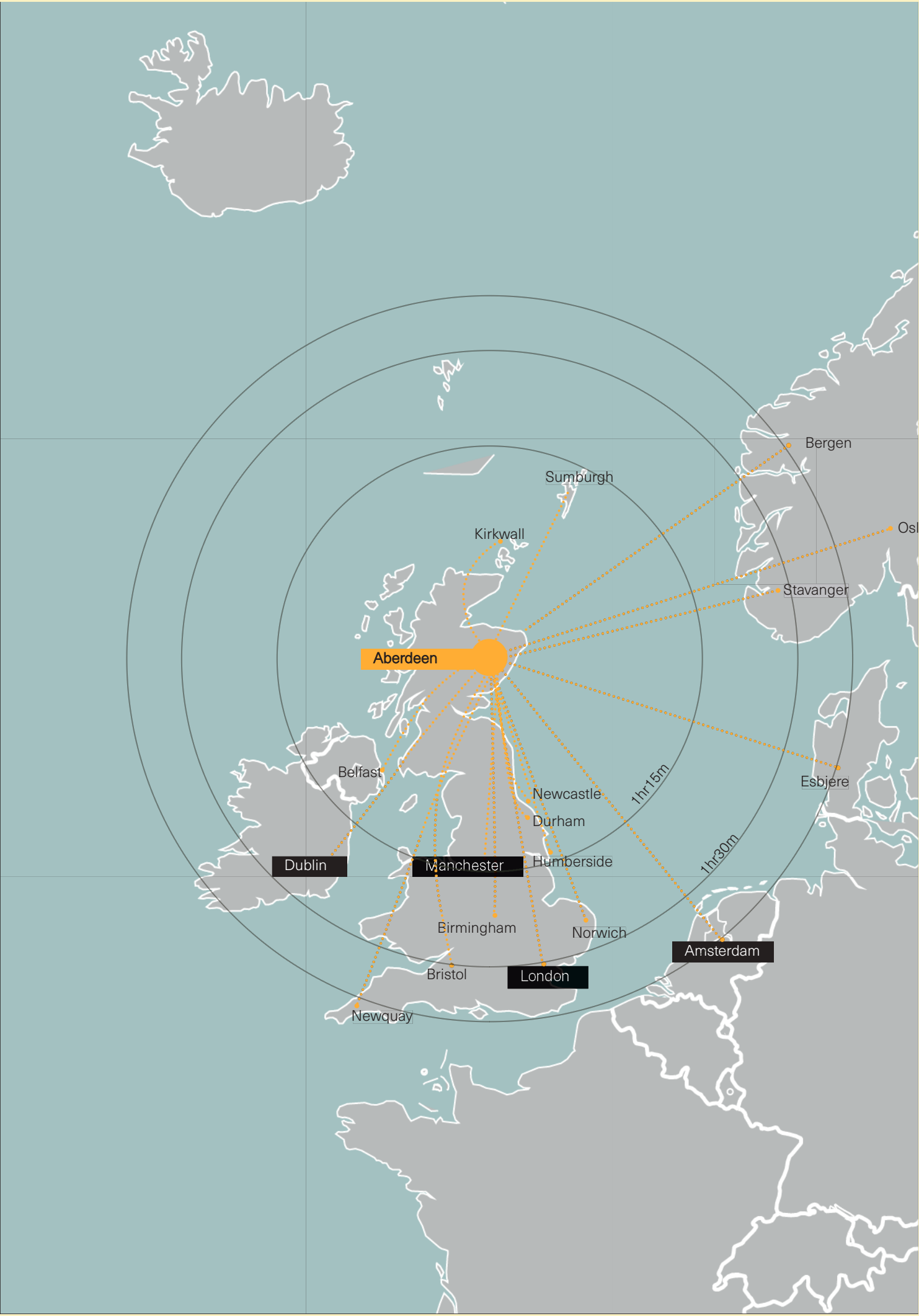


1.0 Context

Historical Context

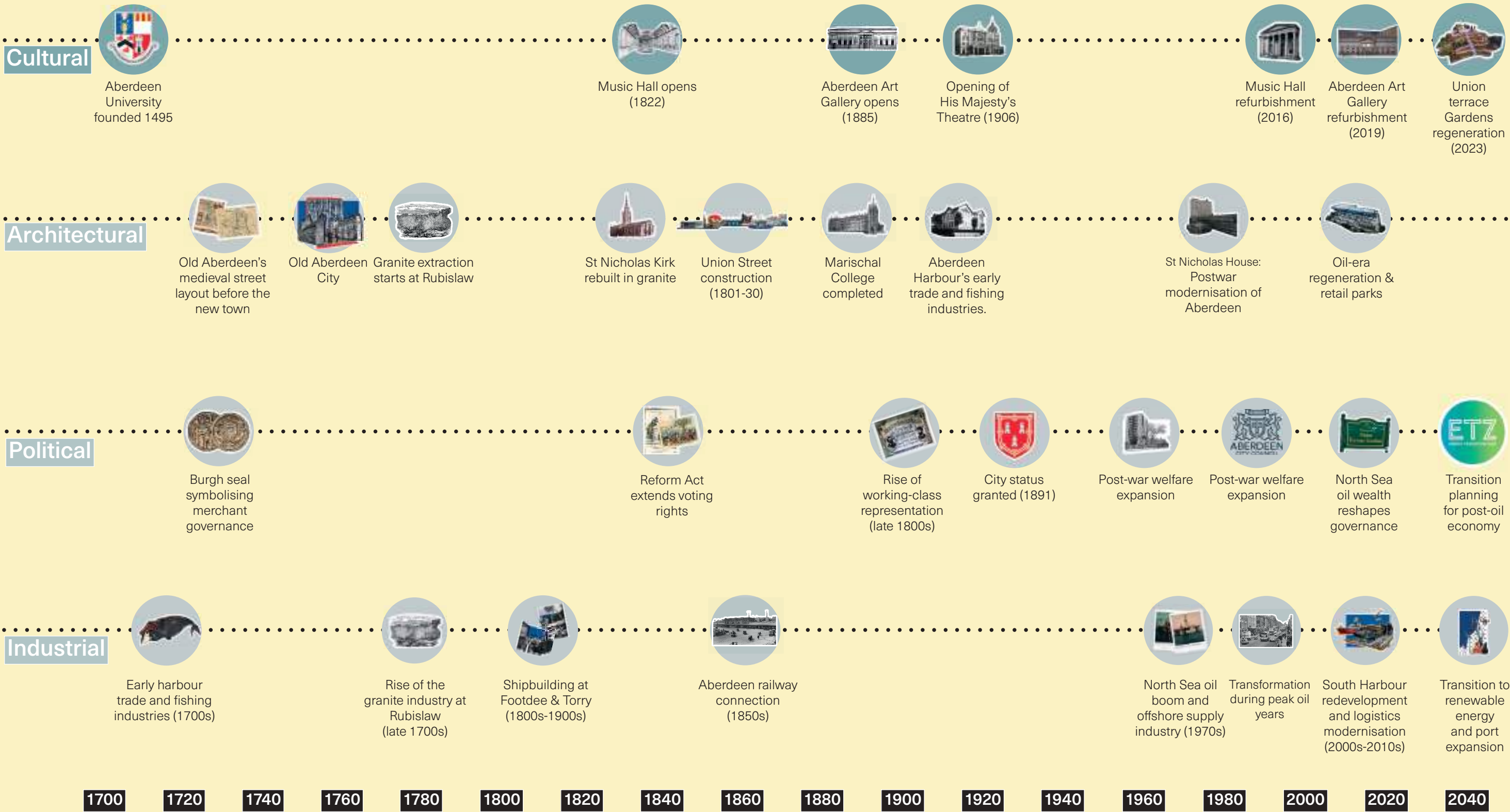
Aberdeen's economy in trade ranged from agricultural to industrial products. Commerce spanned from Europe all the way to Asia, with ships 'Tea Ships' going all the way to China from the port of Aberdeen. Nationally, it traded in wax, cloth, fish, glass and oil. An 'outward facing' city towards commerce of the sea.

Aberdeen's outward-facing maritime economy not only enabled global trade but also attracted visitors and wealth, later reinforced by its central role in North Sea oil production, making the city historically prosperous. Despite this economic richness, the city lacks a strong contemporary cultural heart, and this brief responds by repositioning the harbour as a civic and cultural centre where Aberdeen's wealth, history, and public life are made visible and shared.



Historical Context

Overall Timeline



Historical Context

History of Oil



Emergence & Expansion (1960s-1970s)

Aberdeen shifts from fishing, farming, and manufacturing to an oil-led economy following the discovery of North Sea oil. The city becomes a key offshore hub, with rapid growth in employment, infrastructure, and population driven by oil and gas exploration.



Volatility Exposed (1980s)

The oil downturn of the 1980s led to rising unemployment and economic instability, revealing the city's structural dependence on a single extractive industry. This period marked a turning point, prompting early discussions around economic diversification and resilience.



Global Oil Consolidation of Capital (1990s-2000s)

Following recovery in the 1990s, Aberdeen re-established itself as the "Oil Capital of Europe," hosting major international operators and service firms. Oil and gas activity became deeply embedded in the city's spatial, economic, and institutional structures, shaping urban growth and labour markets.



Managed an Oil-Led Transition Within City (2010s-Present)

While oil and gas remain central to Aberdeen's economy, the city has begun diversifying into renewables, research, and knowledge-based sectors. This phase is characterised by coexistence rather than replacement, with oil expertise underpinning emerging low-carbon industries and influencing current urban development strategies.

Historical Context

Economic Outlier

Aberdeen represents a rare economic outlier within the UK. While many British cities experienced post-industrial decline during the late twentieth century, Aberdeen's economy remained comparatively insulated due to sustained investment and employment linked to North Sea oil. This prolonged period of economic stability shaped a city that did not undergo the same pressures to diversify its economy or cultural infrastructure.

As oil production has declined, however, Aberdeen has reached a critical transition point in which long-standing economic reliance on a single industry has revealed structural and cultural vulnerabilities. This condition makes Aberdeen a particularly relevant site for masterplanning, offering a unique opportunity to explore how culture, public space, and urban density can operate as drivers of long-term resilience and economic diversification in a post-oil city.



George Street, 1984



Union Bridge, 1984



Aberdeen Station, 1983



Context

Masterplan Phasing and Oil Moving out



Phase 1



Phase 2



Phase 3



Phase 4



Phase 5

From Harbour to Westhill

“Oil has no loyalty.”

As land values decline, oil companies are relocating their offices from central Aberdeen particularly the harbour area, to Westhill.



From Harbour to Bridge of Don Industrial Estate

Similarly to the shift toward Westhill, many oil-related offices and service companies have also relocated north to the Bridge of Don Industrial Estate. This move is driven primarily by lower land and rental costs, larger industrial units, and better access for logistics.



From Harbour to South Harbour

Completed in 2023, South Harbour provides Aberdeen with new deep-water berths for larger vessels, relieving pressure on the existing harbour. This creates capacity for redevelopment, cleaner industries, and a more civic, public-facing waterfront.



Historical Context

History of Harbour

Aberdeen's central harbour has historically been the city's primary point of contact with the sea, shaping its development as a trading port from the medieval period onwards. For centuries, it functioned as a working waterfront where fishing, shipbuilding, and maritime trade were closely integrated with everyday urban life. During the twentieth century, however, the expansion of harbour infrastructure to support the oil industry fundamentally altered this relationship, transforming the harbour into a secured industrial zone and progressively limiting public access to the waterfront.



Natural Harbour and Early Use (pre-1800s)

Aberdeen Harbour originated as a naturally formed river mouth shaped by the Dee, with limited early engineering. It functioned primarily as a working harbour for fishing and local trade, closely tied to the growth of the town.



Industrial Expansion **Engineering (19th Century)**

During the 1800s, the harbour was extensively engineered through quay construction, terracing, and land reclamation. These interventions fixed the harbour's edges and enabled increased trade, shipbuilding, and industrial activity.



Industrial (Early-Mid 20th Century) **Working Port**

In the early to mid-1900s, the harbour became a dense industrial landscape. Heavy infrastructure, rail links, and fishing fleets dominated the quays, reinforcing the harbour's role as an economic engine for the city.



Energy-Led (Late 20th Century) **Multi-Use Harbour**

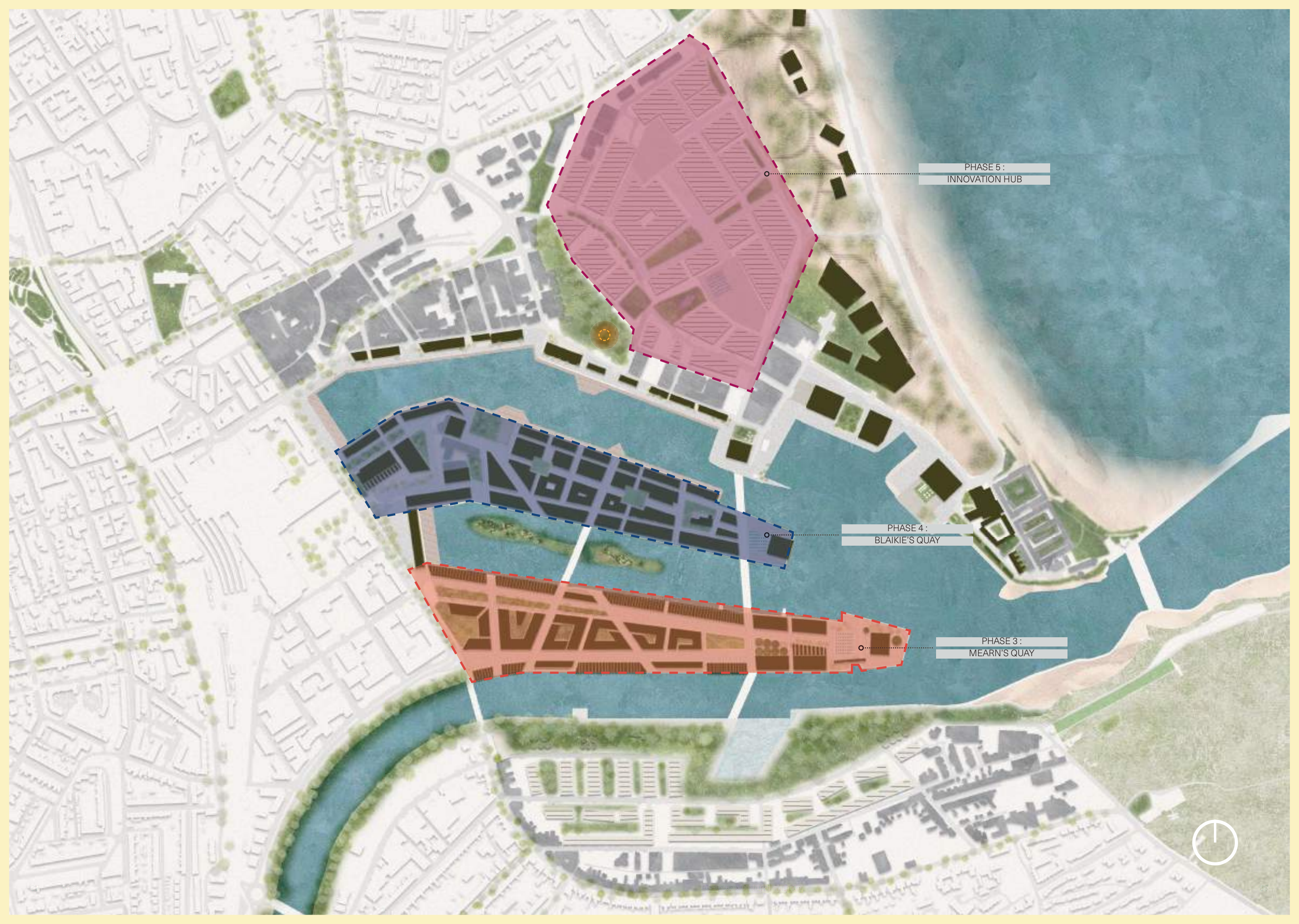
From the late 20th century onwards, the harbour adapted to offshore oil and gas, and more recently to renewables. Expansion into the South Harbour reflects its current role as a flexible, multi-use port supporting energy, cargo, fishing, and cruise activity.

Historical Context

Modern Day Harbour

The oil industry pushed the public's access to water towards the centre of the city away from the port. This included those who previously lived and worked on the port, as employment relied less on the specialisms of locals and more on international investment. During our trip photographs taken of the port, a key space in our masterplan, were through spaces in the fence.





PHASE 5 :
INNOVATION HUB

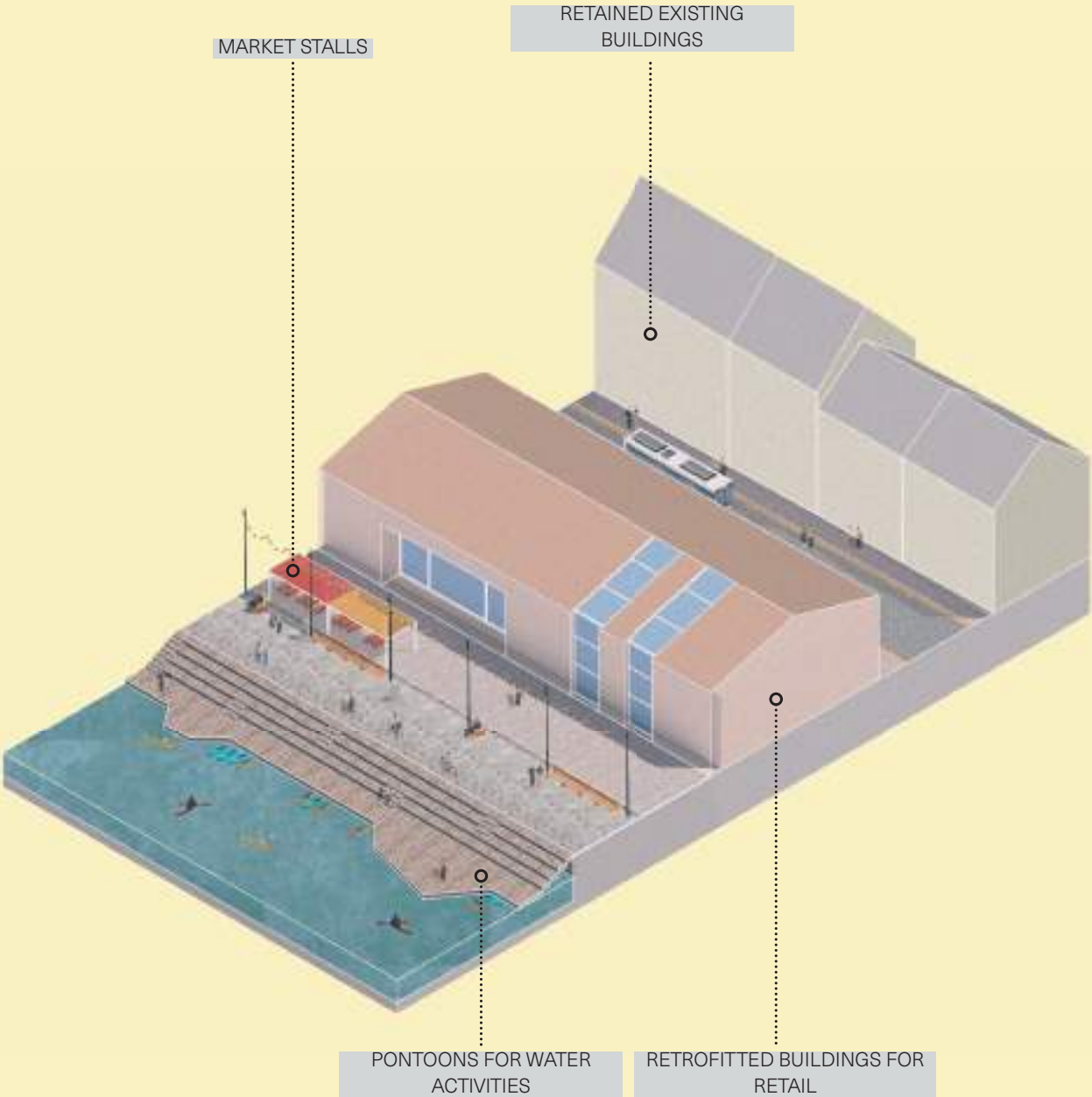
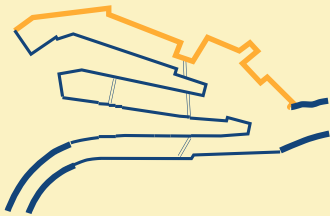
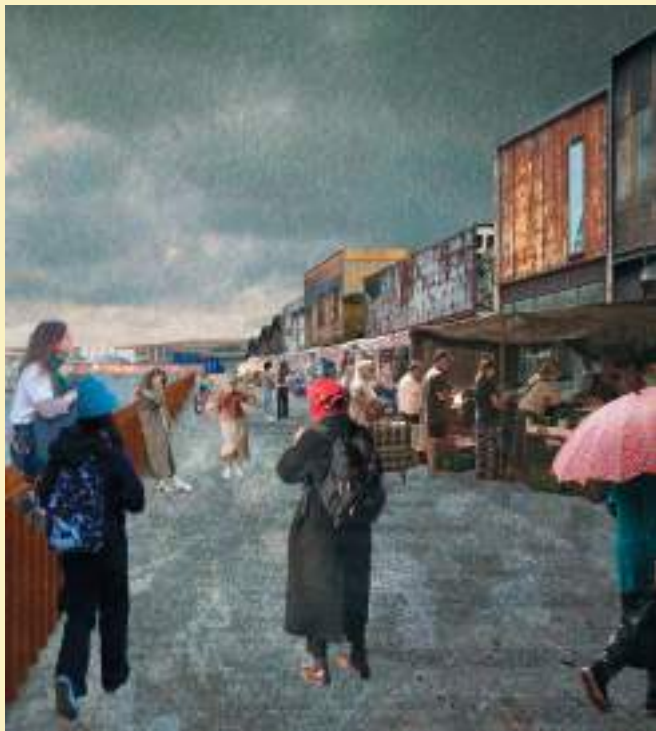
PHASE 4 :
BLAIKIE'S QUAY

PHASE 3 :
MEARN'S QUAY

Waterfront activation

The masterplan

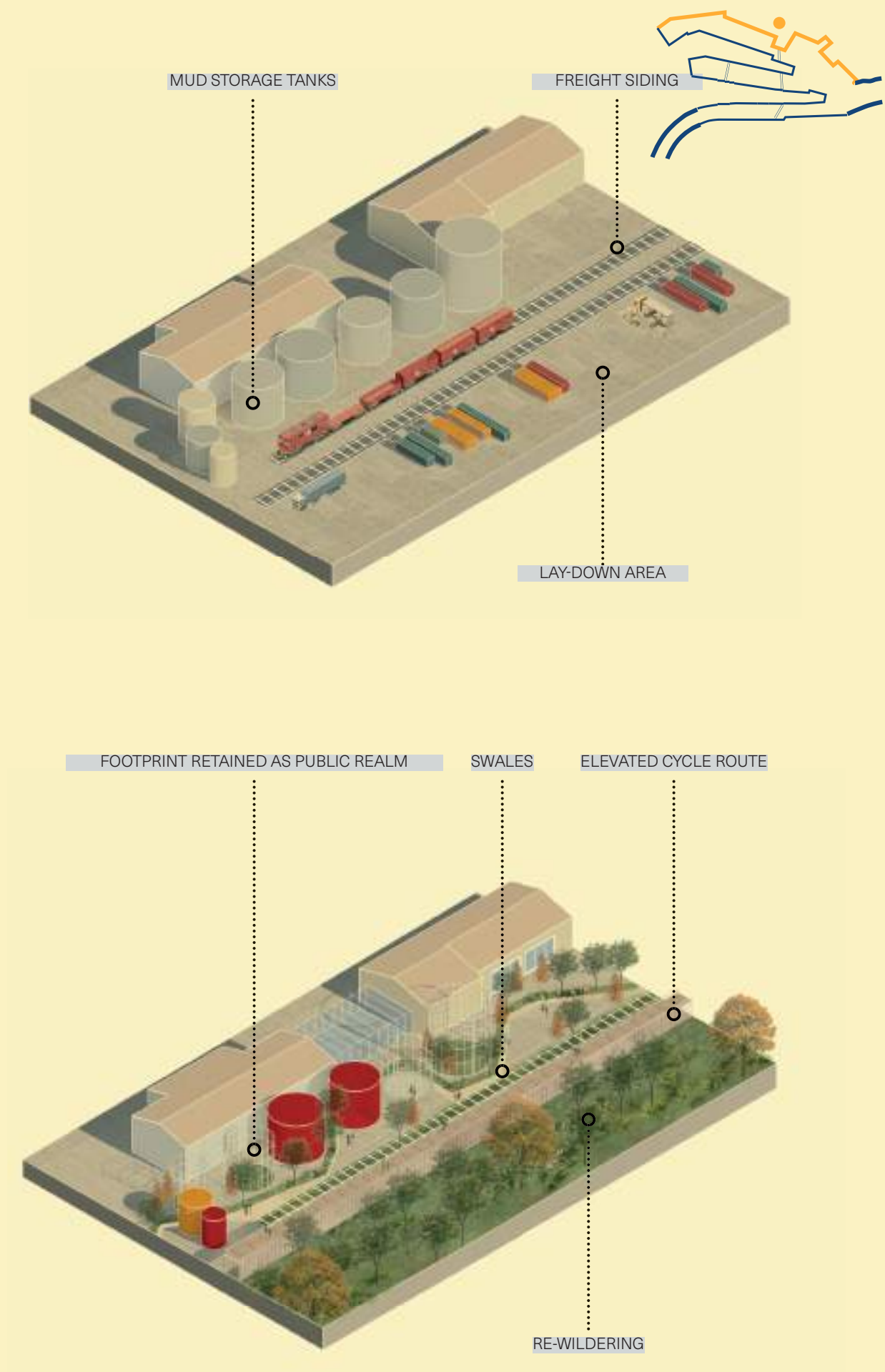
This page illustrates the activation of the waterfront edge adjacent to the site, transforming it from a residual boundary into a public interface with the water. Existing buildings along the quay are selectively retained and retrofitted to accommodate retail, market stalls, and cultural uses, encouraging everyday activity at the water's edge. New stepped terraces and pontoons extend the public realm down to the harbour, allowing direct engagement with the water through seating, events, and water-based activities. Together, these interventions strengthen the relationship between the city, the site, and the harbour, positioning the waterfront as an active civic space rather than a service edge.



Freight Siding

The masterplan

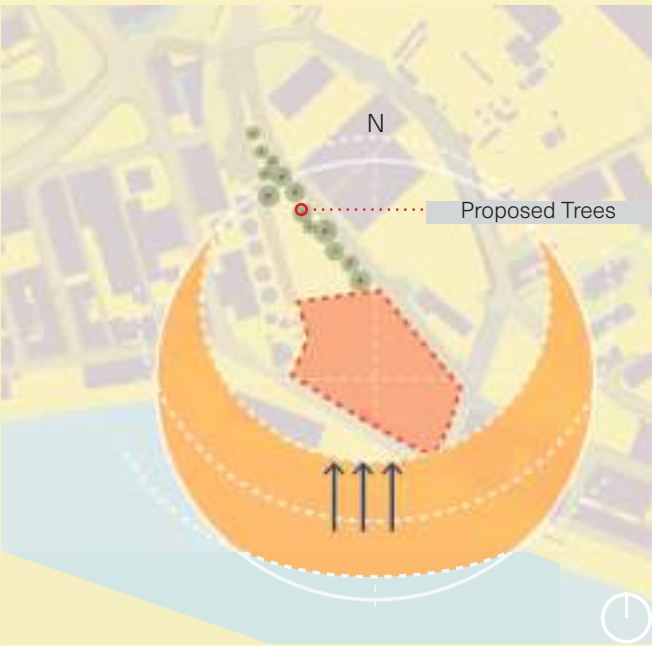
The existing disused freight siding runs directly through the site and is reimagined as a continuous elevated cycling route that cuts through the masterplan. Repurposed as a strategic north-south connector, it links the city centre to the coastal cycle network while prioritising active travel over private vehicles. Constructed using decommissioned oil-rig structures, the route embeds Aberdeen's energy-transition narrative into everyday mobility. At ground level, the former rail corridor is transformed into a landscaped swale, supporting surface water management, improving permeability, and reducing flood risk.



Surrounding context

The site

The total site area is 9,660 m², meaning that a significant proportion of the site is dedicated to landscape and the relationship between the building and its surroundings. This has informed the selection of precedents, which explore how architecture can operate in close dialogue with landscape. The site's proximity to water introduces an additional layer of material and environmental consideration, presenting opportunities for a façade treatment that responds to light, reflection, and atmospheric conditions. Potential flooding risks are addressed at the masterplan scale through the integration of pocket parks, SuDS, and a barrage system.



- Vehicle
- Pedestrian
- Demolish
- Demolish
- Demolish
- Footprint/Volume



Materiality

The site

Aberdeen is often referred to as the “Granite City”, with its character strongly defined by the use of locally quarried grey granite, visible across streets such as Miller Street, Regent’s Quay, and Castle Terrace. Alongside this historic fabric, the area surrounding the site is characterised by industrial sheds, warehouses, and harbour infrastructure, where steel is the dominant material. This industrial context directly informs the project’s material strategy. As part of the wider masterplan, the proposal prioritises recycling and reuse, drawing on existing steel structures from the site and surrounding area to reduce material waste and embed the harbour’s industrial heritage within new construction.

There is, however, another dimension to Aberdeen’s materiality: water. The proximity of the harbour and the North Sea introduces movement, reflection, and variation in colour, counterbalancing the city’s otherwise muted palette. This offers opportunities for façade and material treatments that respond to light and atmosphere, allowing greater richness and variety within the constraints of the local design guidance.



Concrete



Granite



Corrugated Steel



Miller street



Reegent Quay



Regents Quay



Regents Quay

Aberdeen Cultural Foundry



Miller street



Castle Terrace



Regents Quay



Regents Quay

Water Luminosity

The North Sea

In the North Sea, light interaction is largely shaped by suspended sediments, organic matter, and dissolved substances, causing light to scatter and be absorbed rather than penetrate deeply. As water clarity has declined over time, the visual character of the sea is increasingly defined by surface conditions, such as waves, wind, and weather, resulting in a constantly shifting, muted light quality rather than clear depth or transparency.

	NORTH SEA	ABERDEEN HARBOUR
Turbidity	moderate	higher
Clarity	moderate / variable	low near shore
Light penetration	deeper	shallower
Surface reflectance	mix of glint + scattering	mostly diffuse scattering
Colour	blue-green	grey-blue / muted



Aberdeen North Sea at dawn



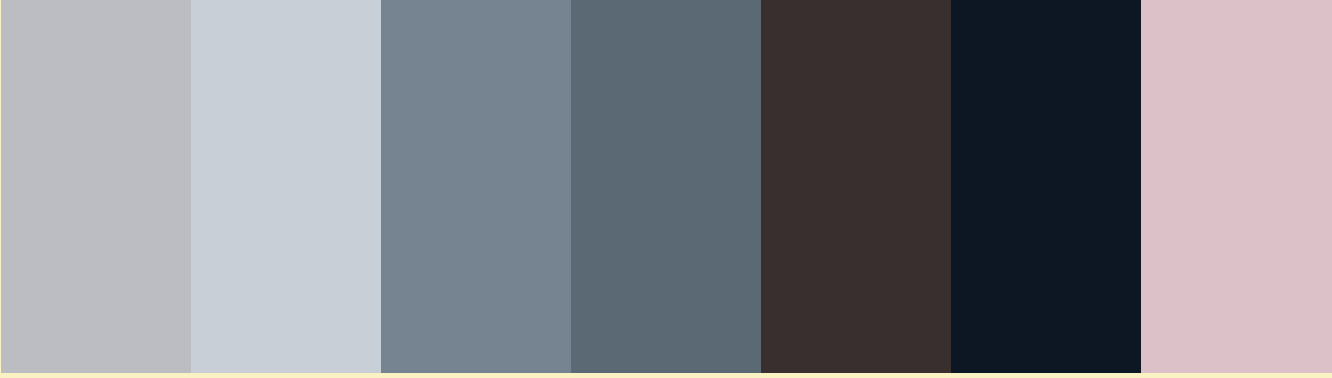
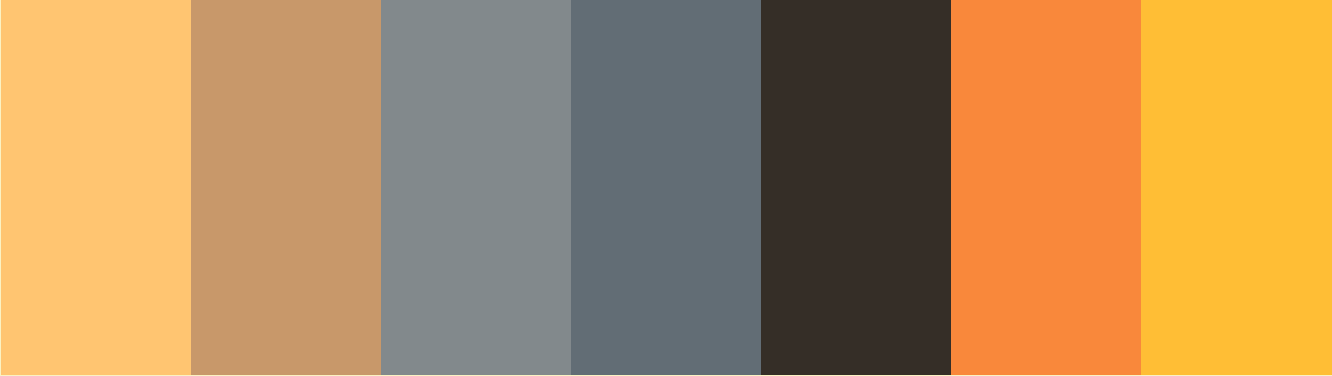
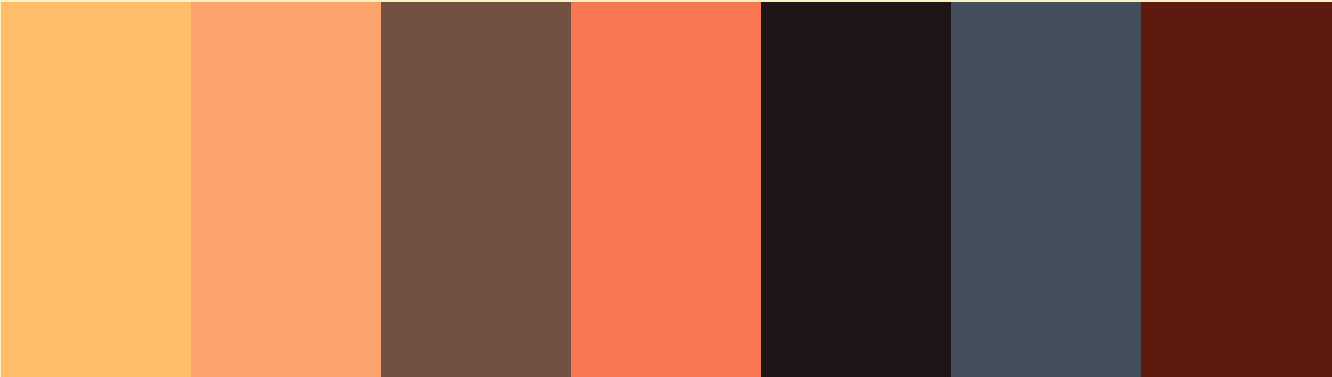
Aberdeen North Sea at dawn



Aberdeen North Sea in the afternoon



Aberdeen North Sea at dusk



Water Luminosity

Aberdeen Harbour

In harbour waters, reflected light is softer and less spectrally pure than in open sea conditions. The water appears muted grey-blue, with brightness governed mainly by surface movement and sun angle rather than colour depth. Architecturally, this produces diffuse atmospheric light rather than strong glare or sharp reflections.



Aberdeen North Sea at dawn



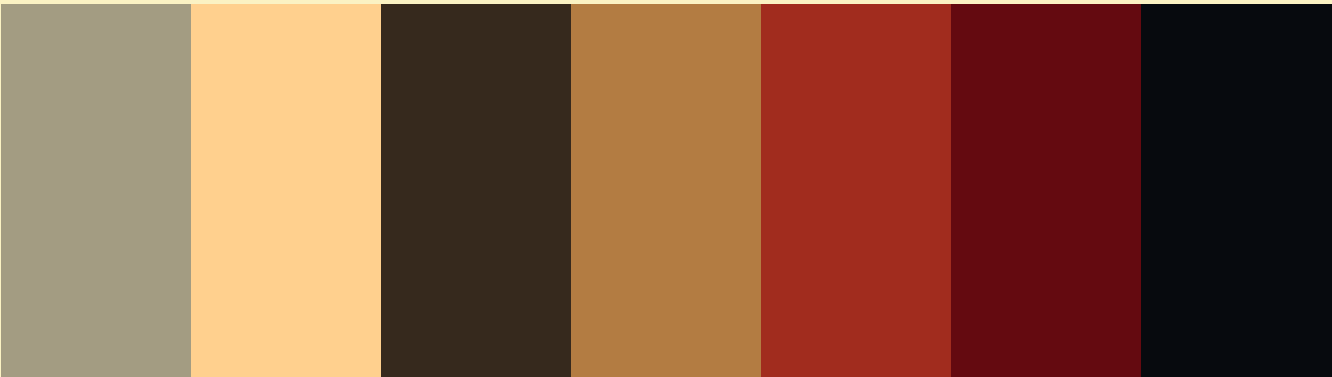
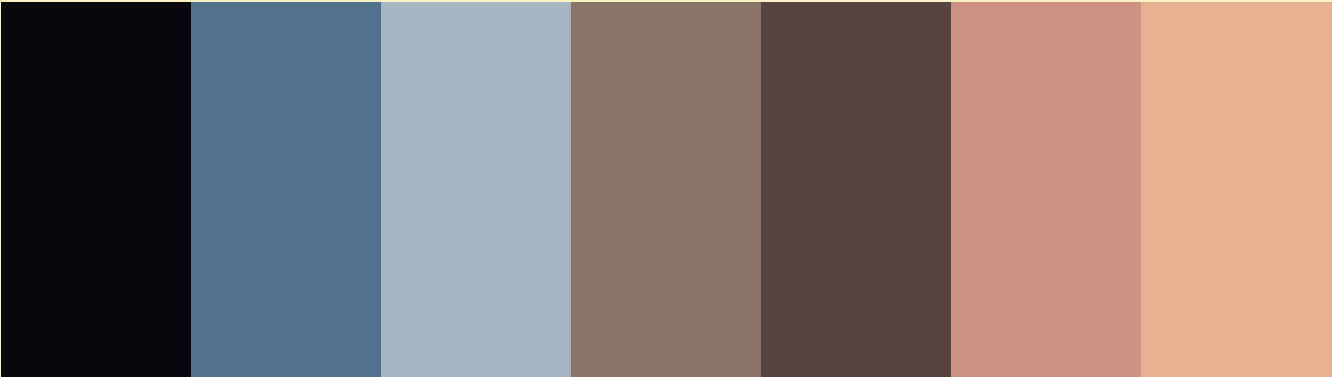
Aberdeen North Sea in the afternoon



Aberdeen North Sea at dusk



Aberdeen North Sea at dusk

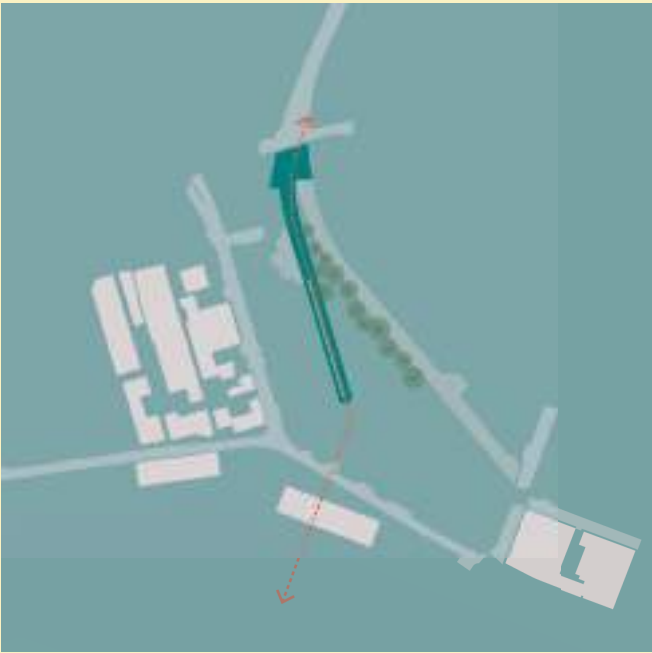


Main Opportunities and Constraints



Main Interfaces

One of the site's main interactions is with water, which forms a significant part of the masterplan. While this interaction is not immediate, it is close enough to influence the design, as the main façade faces this area. The relationship with the surrounding architecture and adjacent roads is also an important consideration.



The freigh site and the proposed elevated cycle route

The freight siding on site has been underused and, as part of the masterplan, is being redeveloped into an elevated cycling route. This will need to be addressed through the site's massing strategy and architectural treatment.



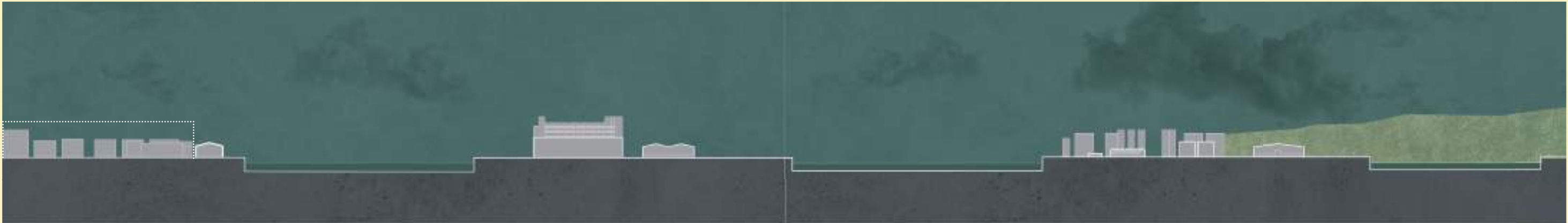
Surrounding existing archietcture

Aberdeen is known for its grey granite architecture; however, the harbour has historically been industrial in character. This context will need to be addressed through the massing, materiality, and interfaces of the proposed building.



Addressing the industrial heritage

The industrial heritage of the site will need to be addressed not only through materiality, but also by responding to the mud tanks located directly on the site. This should be considered through both the landscape strategy and the massing of the proposal.



Section Existing (Long)



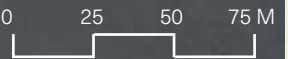
Section Existing (Short)



Section Proposed (Long)



Section Proposed (Short)





2.0 Art Narrative

Tourism



Aberdeen has strong tourism potential linked to its coastal setting and maritime heritage; however, this potential has not yet been fully translated into accessible, everyday urban experiences. Tourism in the city is closely tied to its harbour infrastructure, with the expansion of Aberdeen South Harbour supporting 49 cruise ship calls in 2024 and bringing approximately 240,000 visitors. Major maritime events such as the Tall Ships Races further demonstrate Aberdeen's capacity to host large tourist populations. Despite this growth, limited public access to working harbour areas continues to restrict how visitors engage with the waterfront, highlighting the need for cultural and public spaces that better integrate tourism into everyday urban life.

Culture



Aberdeen has a rich artistic heritage; however, despite this long-standing cultural lineage, the city has often struggled to fully activate and project this potential. From Lord Byron's formative years in the city to its traditions of tailoring and goldsmith work, and through to global figures such as Annie Lennox, Aberdeen has consistently contributed to Scotland's cultural history. Together, these references reveal a creative legacy that is deep and diverse, yet frequently understated and underrepresented within the city's contemporary cultural infrastructure.

Comparison to other Scottish Cities

Aberdeen's cultural output and investment have not translated into the same level of visible cultural infrastructure found in other Scottish cities, contributing to dispersed activity and a weaker collective identity. Although institutions such as Aberdeen Art Gallery drew over 223,000 visits in 2024-25 and total admissions across council museums reached about 320,000, these figures remain modest compared with major attractions in Glasgow and Edinburgh that each draw millions of visitors annually. At the same time, the creative sector contributed an estimated £242 million in gross value added and supported 3,530 jobs in 2018, but still accounts for only about 2 per cent of employment locally compared with 3 per cent nationally, indicating a smaller cultural economy relative to city size and investment. These patterns point to the need for stronger cultural anchors and more visible creative infrastructure that can better support cultural identity, public engagement, and urban vitality.



EDINBURGH



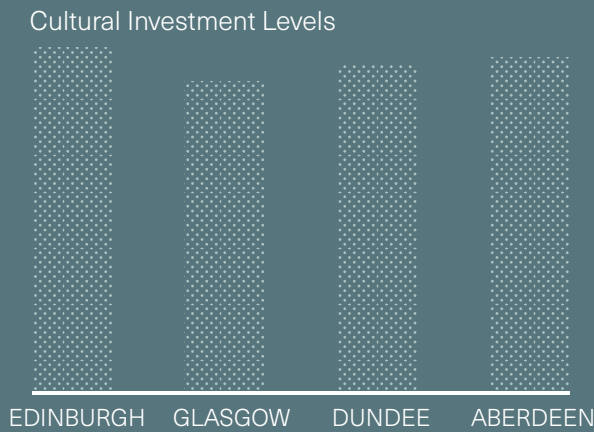
GLASGOW



DUNDEE



ABERDEEN



Aberdeen does not have less cultural funding than the others.



Aberdeen uses its cultural investment less effectively.

Historical Context

Art in Aberdeen

Aberdeen has a rich and long-standing cultural history, particularly in the visual arts, which is evident throughout the timeline below. From early artist-led societies and civic collections to contemporary galleries and independent initiatives, the city has consistently supported artistic production, exhibition, and public engagement.

The Aberdeen Artists Society is established to promote visual art in the city and North-East Scotland, organising exhibitions and supporting artists long before formal galleries existed. It played a central role in cultivating a local artistic community and running annual exhibitions into the early 20th century.



The gallery expanded with additional rooms and a sculpture court (1905), reflecting growing collections and public engagement with art



A group of Gray's School of Art graduates established **Peacock Visual Arts** as a printmaking workshop. Its mission expanded to include making, teaching and showing, offering relief printing, etching, screenprint, lithography and digital fabrication.



Aberdeen Art Gallery underwent a £34.6 million redevelopment led by Hokins Architects, revitalising exhibitions, visitor facilities, learning spaces and sustainability. The project tripled display capacity, improved accessibility and positioned the gallery as a flagship civic cultural space.



1827

1901-1905

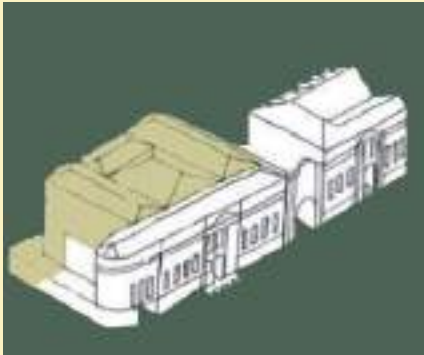
1974

2015-2019



1873-1885

Local collector John Forbes White and others organised exhibitions from 1873, leading to the **establishment of Aberdeen Art Gallery**. Designed by Alexander Marshall Mackenzie and James Matthews, the gallery opened on 7 July 1885 as a civic institution housing fine art.



1925

Cowdray Hall, a concert and performance venue, opened within the gallery complex .

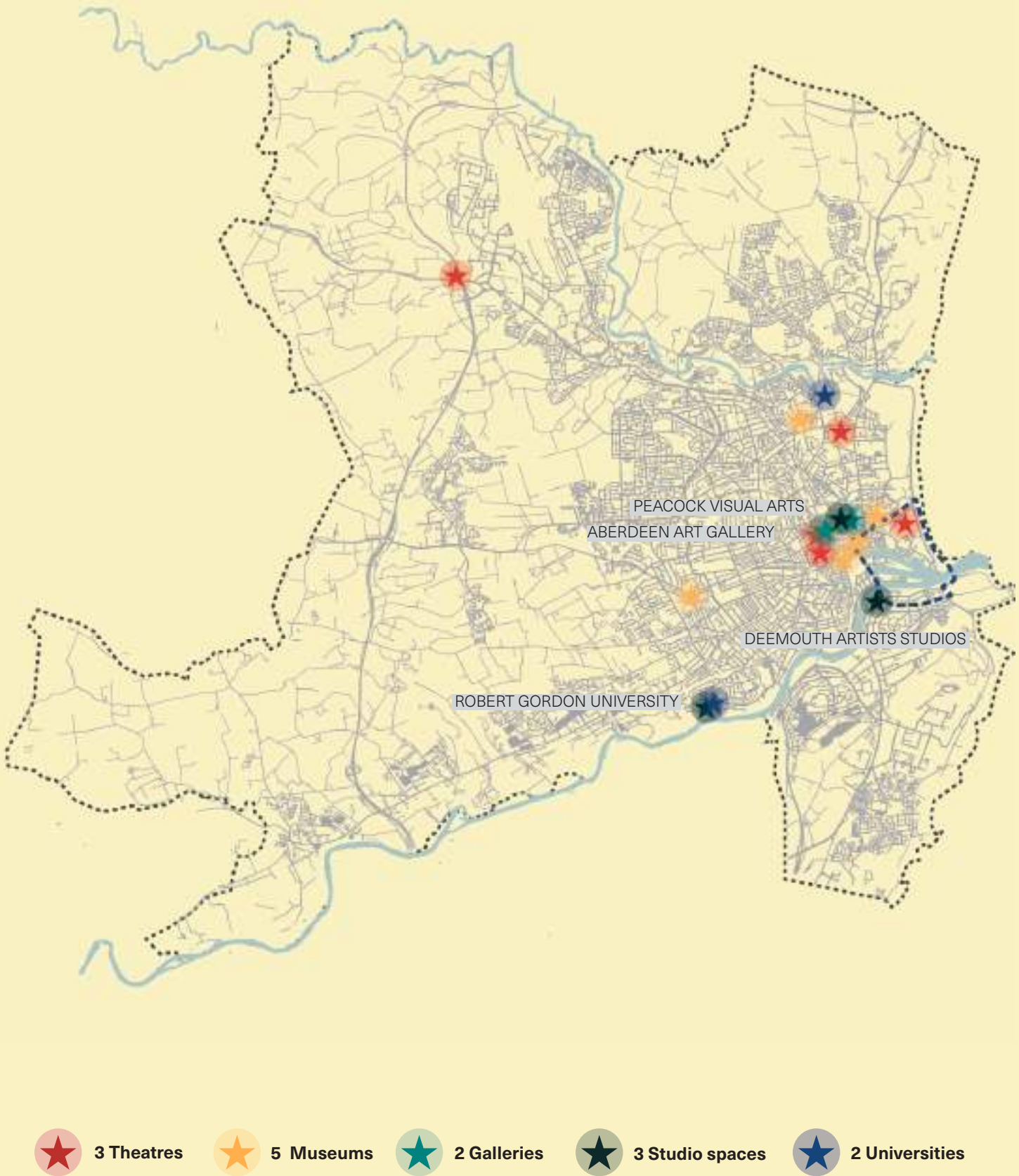


2013

In 2013, Peacock Visual Arts had secured planning permission and the majority of funding for a new arts centre at Union Terrace Gardens. However, the project was dropped after political support shifted towards a competing commercial redevelopment of the site, causing key public funding to be withdrawn and the scheme to be abandoned.

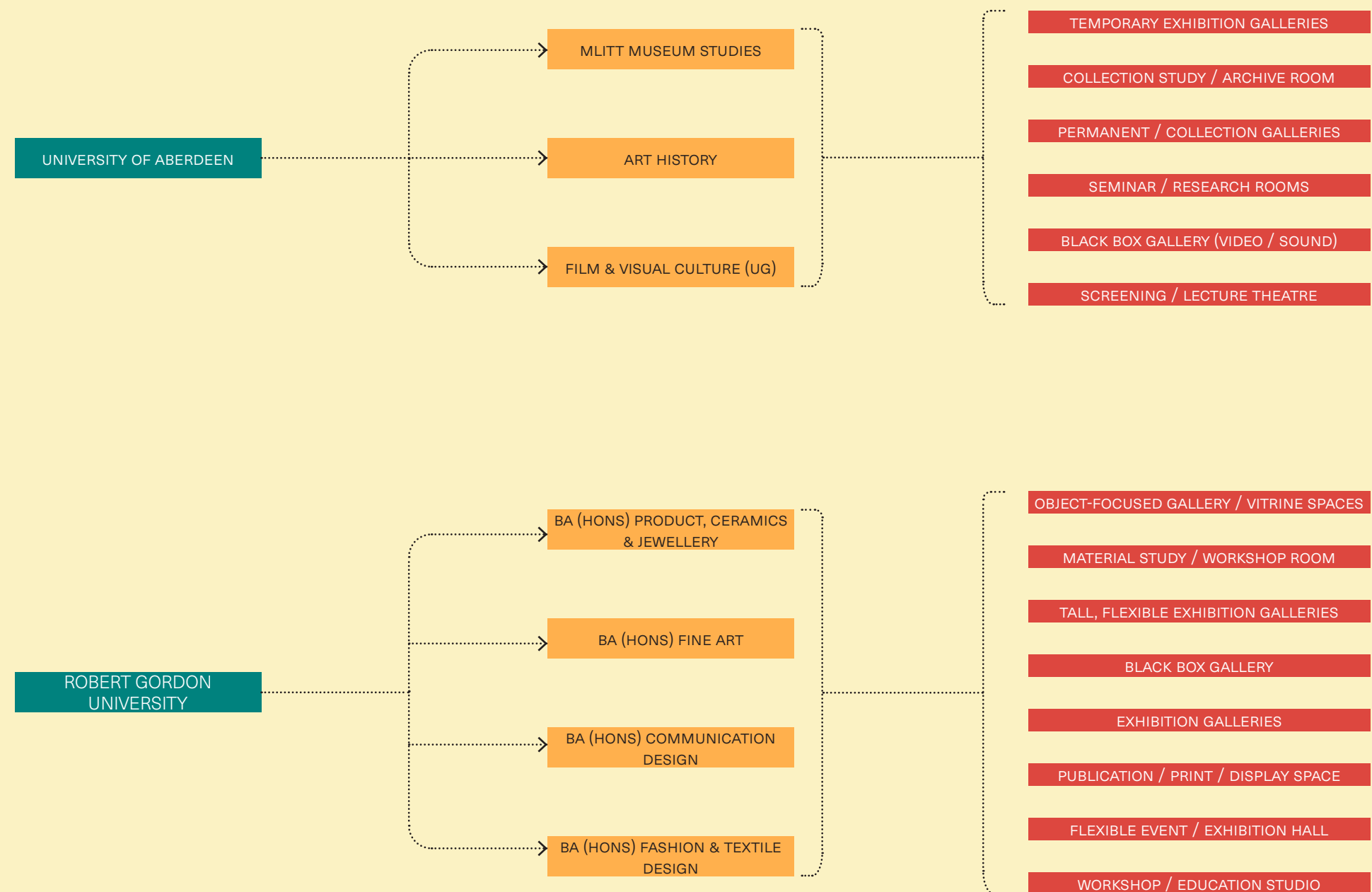
Cultural Institutions Aberdeen

Aberdeen's cultural institutions are anchored by a small number of key venues, most notably Aberdeen Art Gallery, Peacock Visual Arts, and Aberdeen Performing Arts. Aberdeen Art Gallery is the city's primary cultural landmark, recording approximately 200,000 to 300,000 visits per year following its recent redevelopment, while Aberdeen Performing Arts operates three major venues and delivers over 1,000 performances annually. Despite serving a city of around 225,000 residents and a wider regional population, the number of large-scale, publicly accessible cultural institutions remains limited. Much cultural activity is therefore dispersed across small venues and temporary spaces, reducing visibility, placemaking impact, and the ability of culture to act as a strong urban anchor. This imbalance highlights the need for new, integrated cultural infrastructure capable of supporting production, exhibition, education, and public engagement at a scale that reflects Aberdeen's size and cultural output.



University Courses

Given the breadth of creative and theoretical courses offered by the University of Aberdeen and Robert Gordon University, the building is conceived as a shared academic and cultural resource rather than a course-specific facility. Instead of allocating dedicated spaces to individual programmes, a range of flexible galleries, studios, workshops, and research spaces is provided to support overlapping teaching methods, media, and scales of work. This shared-use approach encourages collaboration between disciplines, supports changing pedagogical needs, and allows the building to function as an extension of university teaching while remaining open and accessible to the wider public.



Cultural Institutions Aberdeen

Aberdeen Gallery



Aberdeen Art Gallery is the city’s principal civic art institution, originally opened in 1885 as part of Aberdeen’s late-Victorian cultural investment. Its collection focuses on historic fine art, Scottish painting, modern British art and decorative arts, with limited emphasis on large-scale contemporary installation.

The gallery underwent a major £30+ million redevelopment (2015-2019), introducing new exhibition spaces, improved public access and a contemporary rooftop extension. While the renovation modernised the building, its programme remains largely collection-led and inward-facing, with restricted capacity for experimental, time-based or monumental contemporary work.

Peacock Visual Arts



Peacock Visual Arts is Aberdeen’s leading contemporary visual arts organisation, founded in the 1970s and relocated to its current Castlegate premises in 2012. It operates primarily as a production and learning space, providing studios, workshops, printmaking facilities and small gallery spaces.

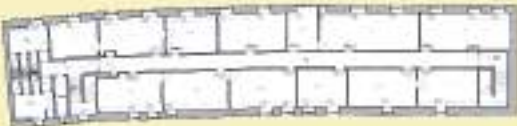
The organisation supports emerging and mid-career contemporary artists, often showcasing experimental, process-driven and socially engaged work. While culturally significant, Peacock’s small scale, limited gallery capacity and inward-facing location restrict its ability to operate as a city-wide or international cultural anchor.

Studios available in Aberdeen
Robert Gordon University - Gray School of Art



The studios at Robert Gordon University are structured around applied, practice-led learning, with spaces designed to support making, testing, and collaboration across art, design, and architecture disciplines. Studios are typically organised as open-plan environments with adjacent workshops, digital labs, and critique spaces, allowing production, review, and iteration to happen in close proximity. Robust materials, exposed services, and flexible layouts accommodate messy processes and changing project scales, while shared circulation and breakout areas encourage informal exchange between students and staff.

Deemouth Artists Studios



Deemouth Artist Studios (D.A.S.) was established in 2019 by Peter Baxter and Allan Watson. The studios occupy adapted, underused office space within Deemouth Business Centre, where the architecture is utilitarian and largely unchanged, allowing tenants to appropriate and personalise their studios according to their creative needs. This flexible, low-intervention approach results in a varied internal character shaped by individual practices rather than a fixed architectural language. Alongside a strong creative community, the project demonstrates how modest, adaptable commercial buildings can be repurposed to support sustained cultural production.



ALLAN WATSON

Peacock Artists Studios



Peacock Visual Arts is an open-access printmaking organisation founded in 1974. It is one of Aberdeen's key cultural assets, supporting artist production and public engagement around print. Peacock is the making arm: a shared printmaking studio used by artists and students. The worm is the public gallery, exhibiting contemporary print, publishing, and archival work with free entry.

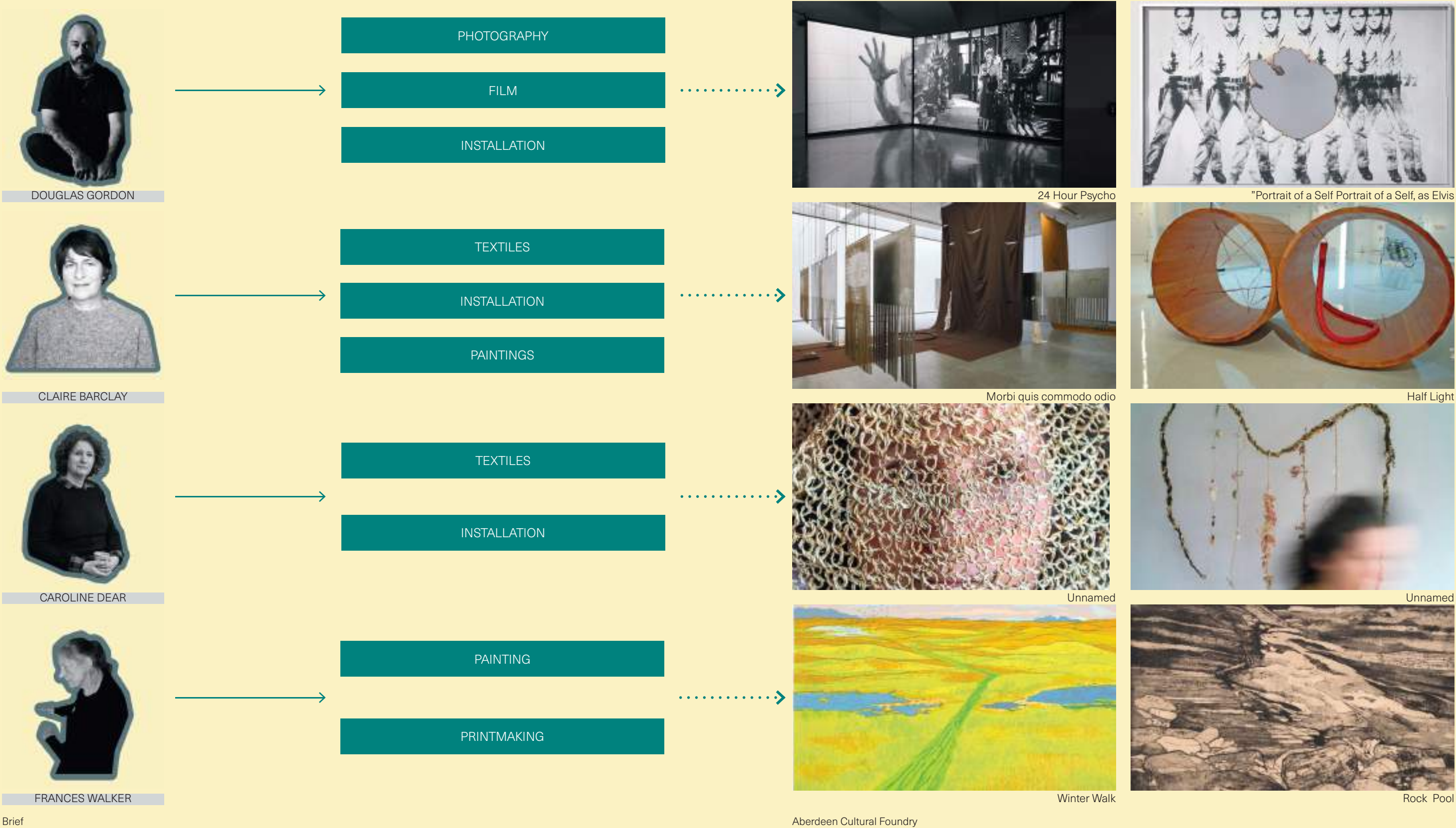
- The Peacock and Worm offers facilities for:
- **Printmaking (screenprint, lithography, etching, relief)**
 - **Typography & publishing (letterpress, risograph, bookbinding)**
 - **Digital / hybrid making (laser cutting)**



FRANCES WALKER

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Artists of North East Scotland and Aberdeen



Emerging Artists of Aberdeen



PHOEBE BANKS



- SCULPTURE
- VIDEO
- CONCEPTUAL TEXT / WRITTEN WORD



Yesterday Nothing Went Awry



Polystyrene Pals



ANNA SHIRRON



- PAPER CUTTING
- PAINTING



Site Specific Installations



Incidental Interiors



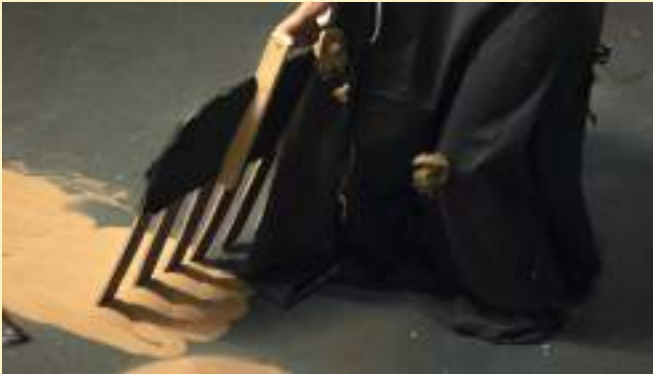
ALEX MCGREGOR



- PERFORMANCE ART
- PRINTMAKING



Perfomance: She is Systematic,



Perfomance: Unnamed



ALLAN WATSON



- SCULPTURE
- FURNITURE DESIGN



tillydrone gateway sculpture



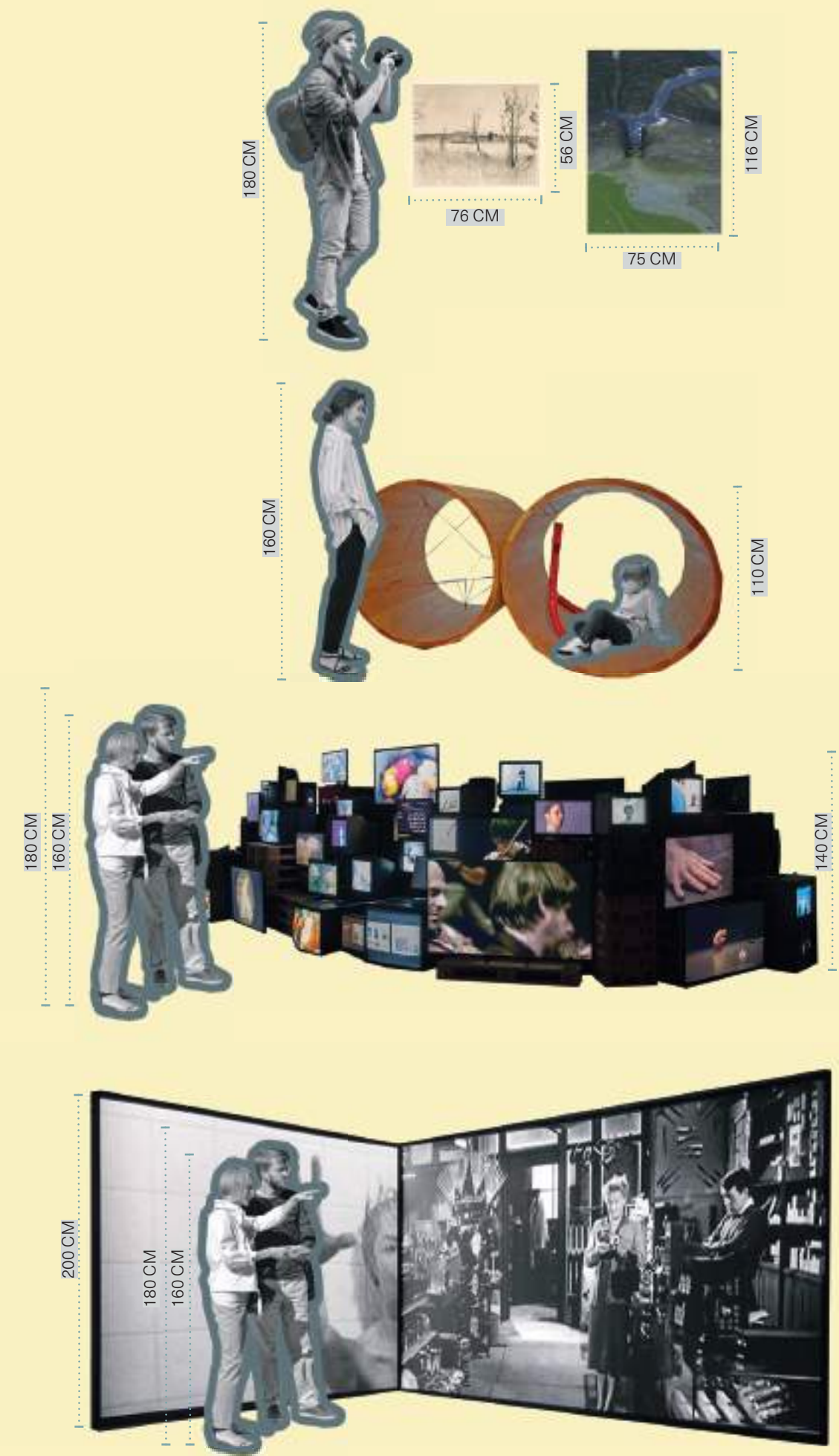
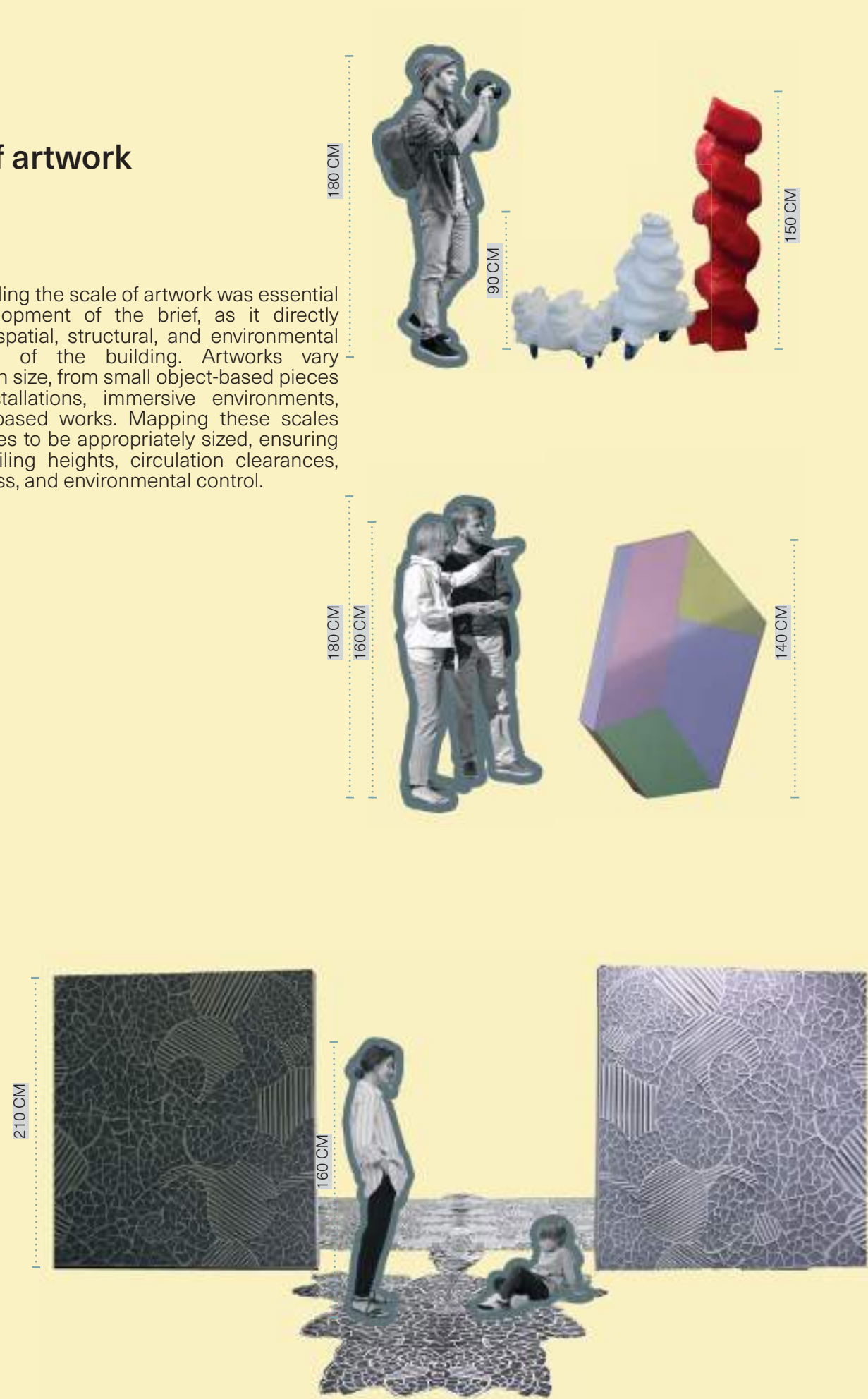
tillydrone gateway sculpture



Structure for a spring day

Scale of artwork

Understanding the scale of artwork was essential to the development of the brief, as it directly informs the spatial, structural, and environmental requirements of the building. Artworks vary significantly in size, from small object-based pieces to large installations, immersive environments, and screen-based works. Mapping these scales allows facilities to be appropriately sized, ensuring adequate ceiling heights, circulation clearances, loading access, and environmental control.





3.0 Brief

Three Pillars

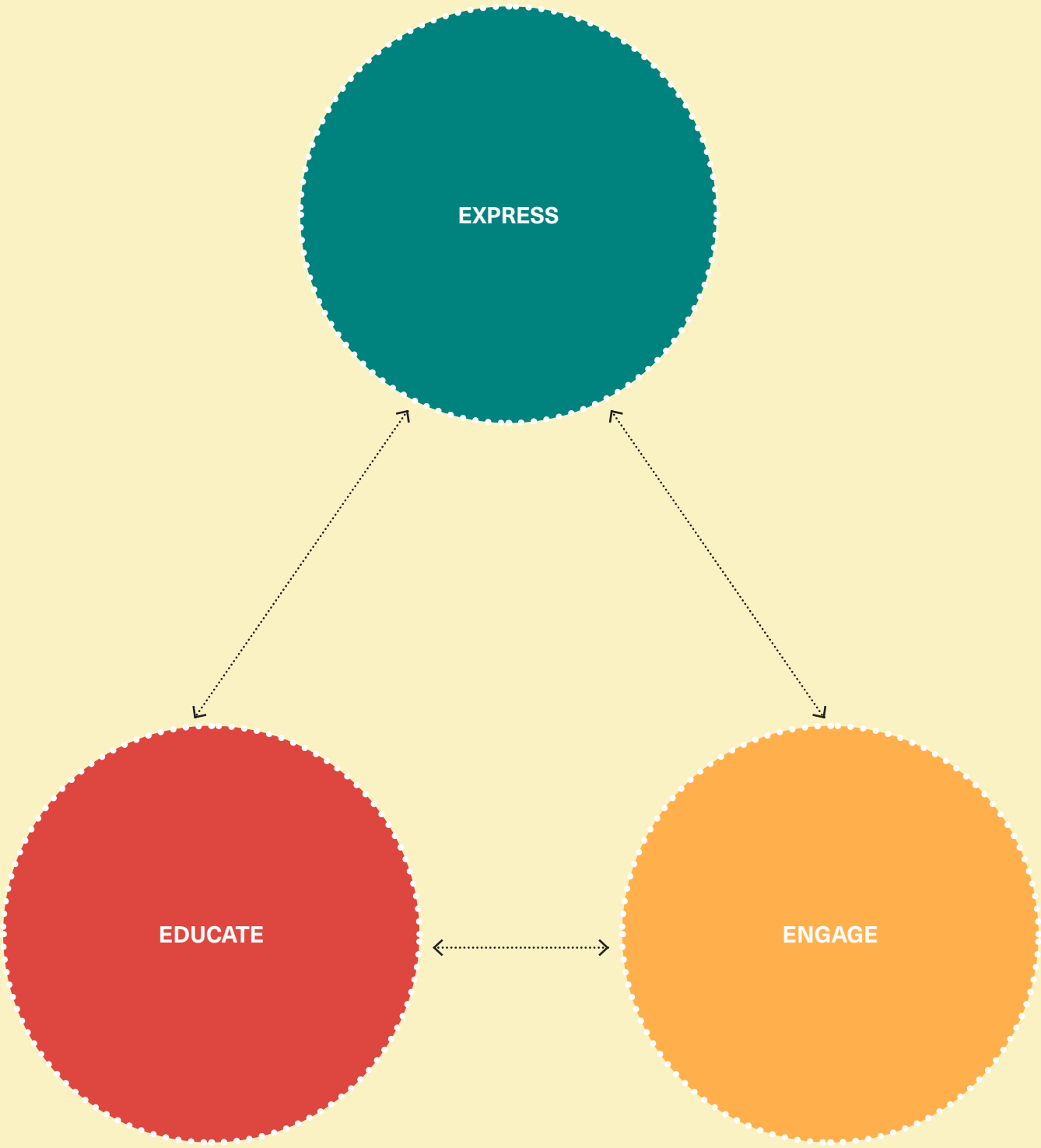
In my design approach, I organise the programme into three interconnected spatial categories: Express, Engage, and Educate. This responds to the cultural needs of Aberdeen, where new spaces must actively speak to people, invite participation, and strengthen the relationship between artistic production and the public realm. The strategy is informed by the precedents analysed, which demonstrate how successful cultural institutions blur boundaries between making, learning, and exhibition to create accessible and socially embedded architecture.

Express spaces are dedicated to artistic production and self-expression, typically private or semi-private environments that support focused making while selectively allowing public access to reveal and demystify creative processes.

Educate spaces operate across both public and private realms, supporting learning, discussion, and knowledge exchange without always being tied to the display of finished work.

Engage spaces are primarily public-facing, hosting exhibitions, events, and informal encounters that position art as a shared and social experience.

All three categories are intentionally interlinked, encouraging fluid movement between making, learning, and public engagement.



Users

The building is designed to support four main user groups, each with distinct patterns of use that overlap throughout the day and week.

Local artists are the primary long-term users of the building. They typically occupy studios and making spaces during standard weekday working hours, with extended use into the evenings when preparing exhibitions, installations, or events.

Students and academics from local universities use the building more flexibly. They often arrive later in the morning and remain into the afternoon or early evening, using teaching spaces, workshops, and study areas, with activity increasing during term time.

Local residents and visitors, meaning people living in Aberdeen, tend to engage with the building outside standard working hours. They primarily use the public galleries, events spaces in the evenings and at weekends as part of their social and leisure routines.

Tourists follow a more seasonal and daytime-focused pattern of use. Visits are concentrated during late morning and afternoon hours, particularly at weekends and during the summer months, when exhibitions become key attractions.



LOCAL ARTISTS



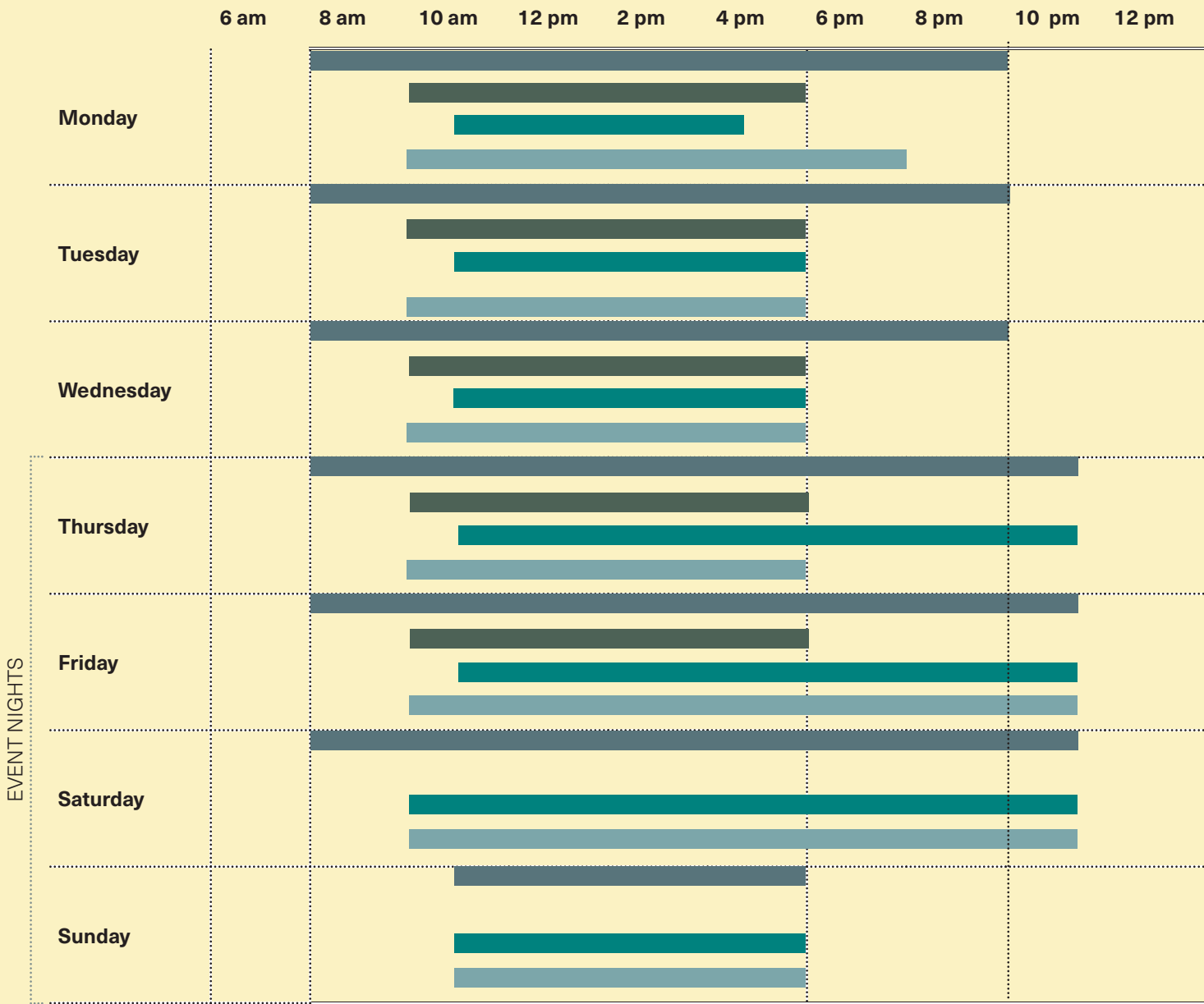
STUDENTS AND ACADEMICS



LOCAL RESIDENTS



VISITING TOURISTS



Schedule of accommodation

Making “Where ideas become physical.”

Idea generation
Material testing
Making and fabrication
Iteration and work-in-progress

Robust, flexible spaces with good daylight, generous height, and direct access to tools and storage. With selective visibility.

Reflecting “Where making is questioned and developed.”

Research and reference
Learning and contextualisation
Critique and feedback
Reflection and revision

Calm, controlled spaces with even light, good acoustics, and flexible layouts for learning, discussion, and critique

Sharing “Where work enters public life.”

Exhibition and presentation
Performance and events
Public interpretation
Social exchange and feedback

Open, accessible spaces with clear circulation, flexible layouts, and strong links to public and external areas.

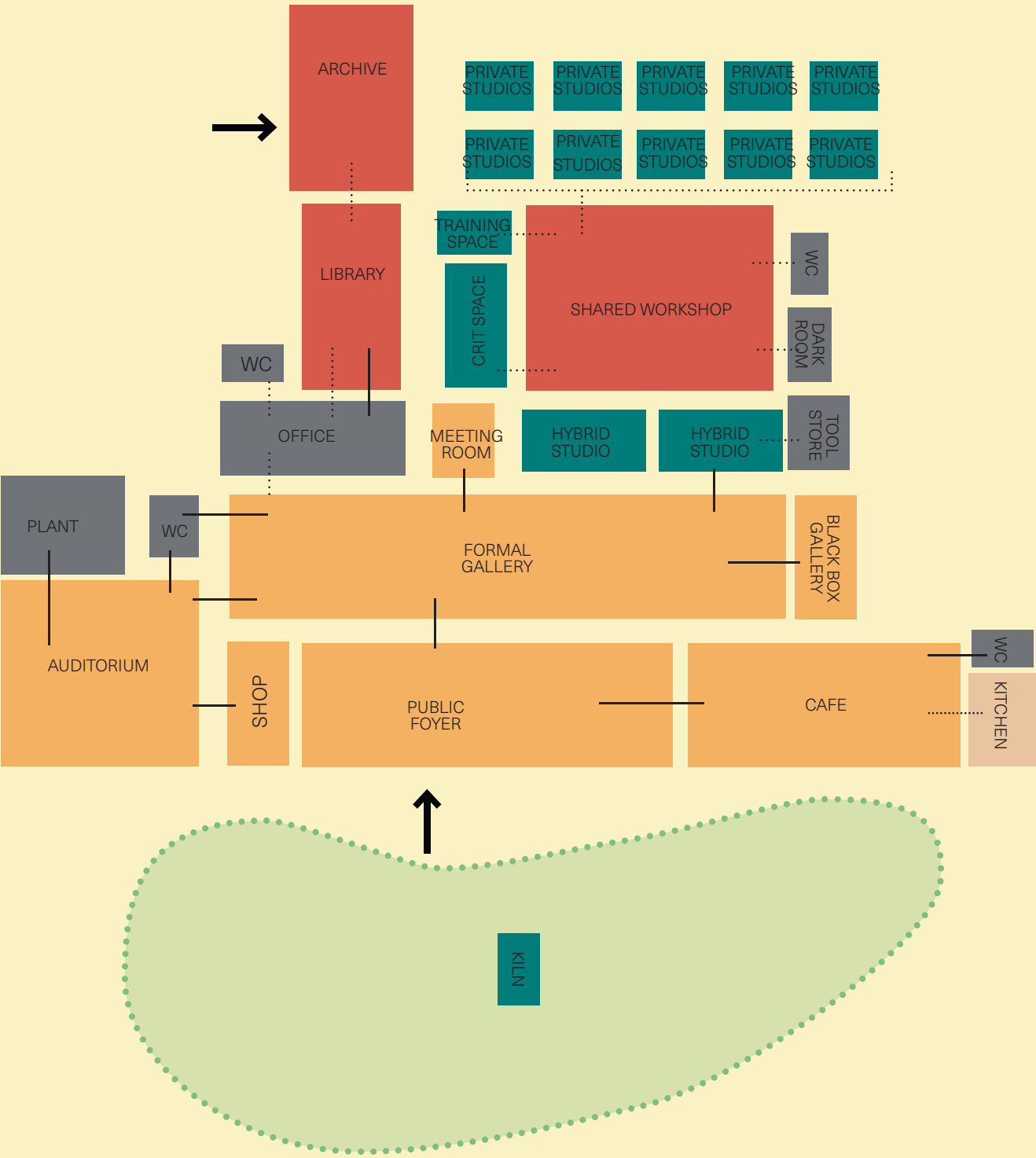
EXPRESS

EDUCATE

ENGAGE

Kiln
Hybrid Studio Galleries (2 units)
Private Artist Studios (10 units)
Shared Making Workshop
Material & Tool Store
Print room
Seminar / Lecture Room
Study Archive / Handling Room
Art Library / Reading Room
Artist Support / Crit Space
Public Foyer
Café
Shop / Zine
Event / Performance Space
External / Semi-covered Space
Formal Exhibition space
Black Box gallery





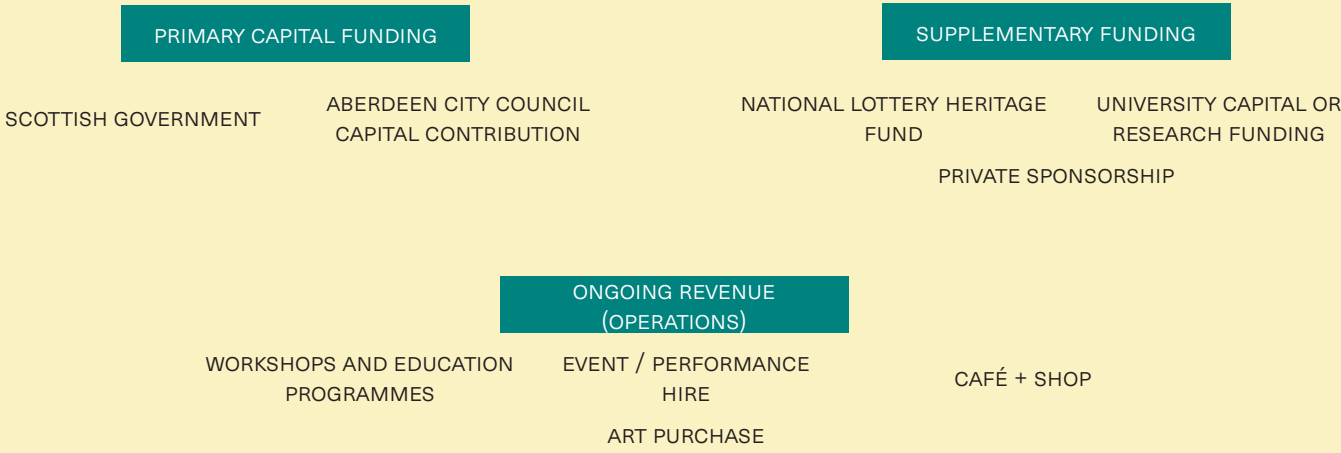
SPACE	AREA	NOTES
Private Studio-Galleries (10 × 25 m²)	250 m²	
Hybrid Studio-Galleries (2 × 50 m²)	100 m²	While hybrid studio-gallery spaces can offer insight into artistic process, constant public exposure can undermine working conditions. This project therefore limits hybrid studios to one carefully controlled space, prioritising artist autonomy while allowing occasional public engagement; residency length: 2/3 months
Shared Making Workshop	300 m²	Could be used by artists and visitors
Kiln room	20 m²	
Darkroom (Photography)	20 m²	
Training Workshop (Performance-based Artists)	20 m²	
Artist Support / Crit Space	45 m²	
Studio Archive	240 m²	
Auditorium / Performance Space	250 m²	
Library	120 m²	
Public Foyer	300 m²	
Formal Exhibition Space	500 m²	
Black Box Exhibition Space	48 m²	Part of the formal exhibition space
Café (Seating Area) / Restaurant	220 m²	
Shop / Zine Area	60 m²	
Sales / Meeting Space	30 m²	
Kitchen (Café)	55 m²	
Office	90 m²	
Public Toilets	80 m²	
Staff Toilets	20 m²	
Event Furniture Store	15 m²	
Cleaners' Store	15 m²	
Material & Tool Store	30 m²	
Net programmed spaces	2683 m²	
Total incl. plant + circulation	3348 m²	

Client and Financing

Client and Partner Structure
Aberdeen City Council acts as the primary client, leading the project as part of the harbour’s cultural regeneration. Creative Scotland and Peacock Gallery and D.A.S. support curatorial direction and funding alignment, with the University of Aberdeen and Robert Gordon University contributing educational and research links. Long-term operation is managed by Aberdeen Cultural Trust.

Financing Structure
The project is funded through a mixed public model, led by the Scottish Government and Aberdeen City Council, with additional support from the National Lottery Heritage Fund, universities, and private sponsorship. Ongoing revenue is generated through education programmes, events, and commercial uses such as the café, shop, and art sales.

Costing
Industry cost data shows that typical UK construction costs range from around £1,900-£3,040/m², with an average of approximately £2,450/m², while more complex projects can exceed £4,000/m². Museums and galleries generally sit above standard commercial buildings due to higher-quality finishes, specialist services, and environmental control requirements. A realistic cost range for a gallery building is therefore £2,400-£3,500/m², which reflects these added complexities while remaining appropriate for a regional Scottish context such as Aberdeen and below London market levels.



Costing

SPACE	AREA	COST PER M²	OVERALL COST
Private Studio-Galleries (10 × 25 m²)	250 m2	£2,800	£700,000
Hybrid Studio-Galleries (2 × 50 m²)	100 m²	£2,900	£290,000
Shared Making Workshop	300 m²	£2,700	£810,000
Kiln room	20 m²	£2,500	£50,000
Darkroom (Photography)	20 m²	£2,500	£50,000
Training Workshop (Performance-based Artists)	20 m²	£2,700	£54,000
Artist Support / Crit Space	45 m²	£2,700	£121,500
Studio Archive	240 m²	£2,750	£660,000
Auditorium / Performance Space	250 m²	£3,400	£850,000
Library	120 m²	£2,750	£330,000
Public Foyer	300 m²	£2,850	£855,000
Formal Exhibition Space	500 m²	£3,150	£1,575,000
Black Box Exhibition Space	48 m²	£3,150	£151,200
Café (Seating Area) / Restaurant	220 m²	£2,800	£616,000
Shop / Zine Area	60 m²	£2,800	£168,000
Sales / Meeting Space	30 m²	£2,500	£75,000
Kitchen (Café)	55 m²	£2,500	£137,500
Office	90 m²	£2,500	£225,000
Public Toilets	80 m²	£2,600	£208,000
Staff Toilets	20 m²	£2,600	£52,000
Event Furniture Store	15 m²	£2,200	£33,000
Cleaners' Store	15 m²	£2,200	£33,000
Material & Tool Store	30 m²	£2,400	£72,000
Plant Room (with equipment) (8%)	215 m²	£2,600	£558,064
Circulation (20%)	450 m²	£2,400	£1,080,000
Subtotal	3347 m²		£9,270,264.00
Landscaping and External Works (10%)			£927,026.40
Allowance for Risk (15%)			£1,390,539.60
Consultants and Statutory Fees (20%)			£1,854,052.80
Subtotal			£13,441,882.80
Location Adjustment Factor (-3%)			-£672,094.14
Total			£12,769,788.66

Building Regulations

The proposed museum and gallery will be designed and constructed in accordance with the Building (Scotland) Regulations 2004, as amended, and guided by the Scottish Technical Handbooks (Domestic and Non-Domestic).

Given the public, cultural, and assembly nature of the building, particular emphasis is placed on safety, accessibility, environmental performance, and the protection of occupants, collections, and staff.

The main regulatory standards informing the design are outlined below.

- **Section 2: Fire** - public assembly building with high occupancy, complex layouts (galleries, studios, workshops); protection of both people and artworks
- **Section 3: Environment** - fully public building; Crowd movement during exhibitions/events; vertical circulation (stairs, lifts, ramps)
- **Section 4: Safety** - museums require controlled internal environments; studios introduce ventilation, extraction, and moisture risks.

SECTION 1:
STRUCTURE
Structural stability, disproportionate collapse, loading, ground movement.

SECTION 2:
FIRE
Means of escape, fire detection and alarm systems, compartmentation, smoke control, fire resistance.

SECTION 3:
ENVIRONMENT
Site preparation, resistance to moisture, ventilation, sanitation, drainage, and indoor air quality.

SECTION 4:
SAFETY
Protection from falls, collision, impact, accessibility, crowd movement, glazing safety, stairs, ramps, and handrails.

SECTION 5:
NOISE
Sound insulation and acoustic performance between spaces and from external sources.

SECTION 6:
ENERGY
Carbon emissions, fabric efficiency, building services, lighting efficiency, and energy performance.

SECTION 7:
SUSTAINABILITY
Water efficiency, material choice, waste reduction, climate resilience, and overall sustainable design measures.

Scottish Technical Handbook (Non-Domestic)
from 1 January 2025

Environmental Approach

Low-Carbon Energy Integration

The building is designed to connect to a proposed district heat network, supported by renewable electricity from offshore wind and on-site photovoltaic generation. This enables low-carbon heating and cooling through a heat exchanger interface, reducing reliance on fossil fuels and supporting the wider decarbonisation of the city's energy infrastructure.

Ground Source Heat Network

The site's expansive landscape context allows for the installation of a localised ground source heat pump system, using either horizontal or vertical arrays, to further reduce operational carbon emissions.

Circular Economy and Material Reuse

Although existing industrial sheds on the site are largely removed, materials salvaged from demolition are reused within the new gallery where possible. Reclaimed steel, timber, slate, and local granite are repurposed for façades, landscape elements, and public realm features, supporting circular economy principles and reducing embodied carbon.

Low Embodied Carbon Material Strategy

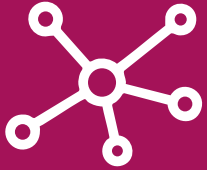
New materials are selected based on their embodied carbon performance, with a strong emphasis on locally sourced materials from Aberdeen, north-east Scotland, and northern England. This reduces transport emissions while reinforcing regional identity and long-term durability.

Long-Term Adaptability

The gallery is designed for long-term flexibility, with robust structural systems and adaptable internal layouts that allow future reuse and reconfiguration. This extends the building's lifespan and reduces the need for carbon-intensive redevelopment over time.

Passivhaus standard

The building is designed to meet Passivhaus principles, using a fabric-first approach with high levels of insulation, airtight construction, and reduced thermal bridging to minimise heat loss. Triple-glazed windows and mechanical ventilation with heat recovery (MVHR) ensure efficient energy use, stable internal conditions, and high thermal comfort with minimal operational energy demand.



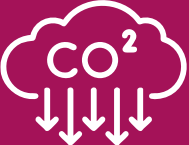
Low-Carbon Energy Integration



Ground Source Heat Network



Circular Economy and Material Reuse



Low Embodied Carbon Material Strategy



Long-Term Adaptability



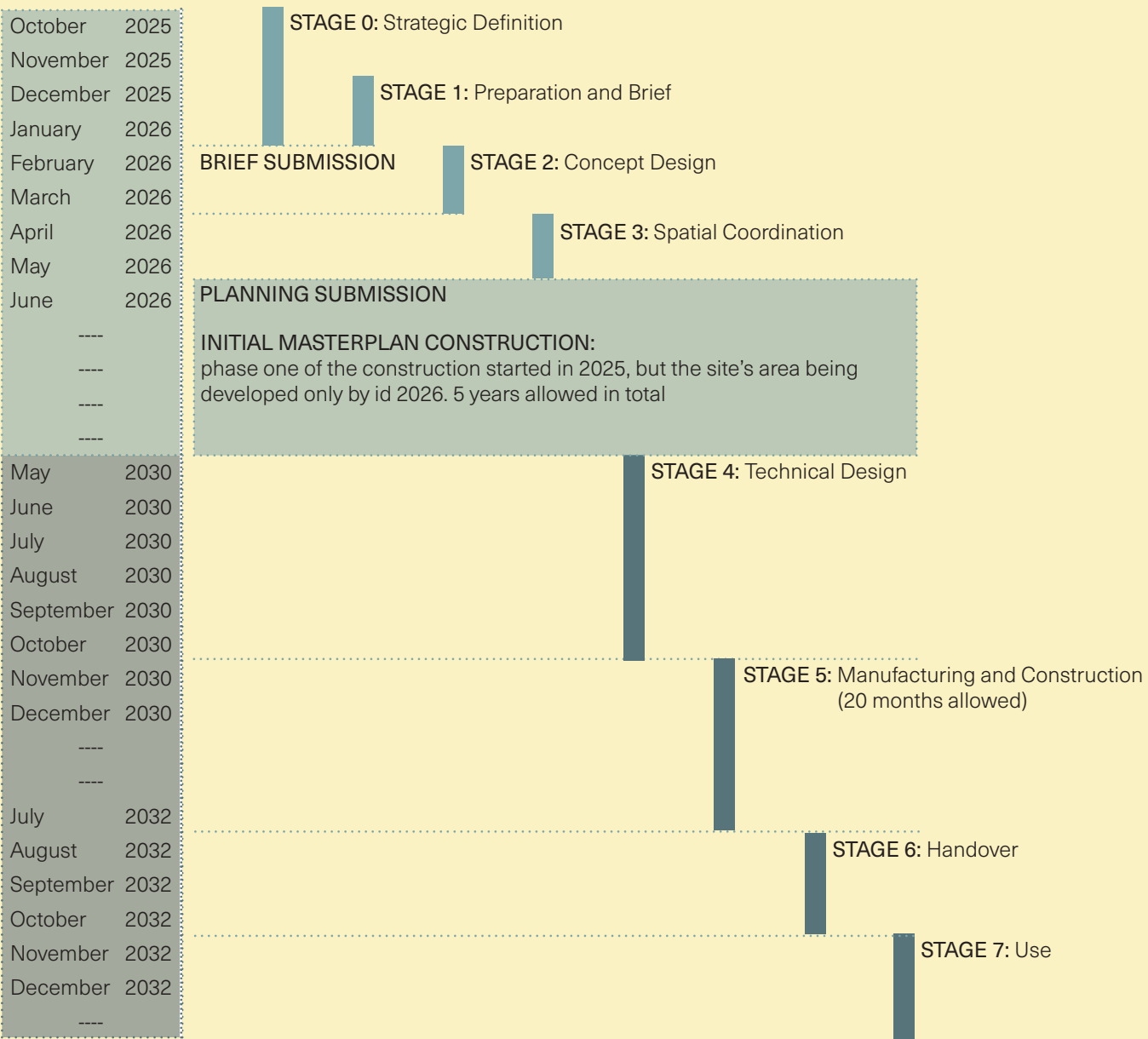
Passivhaus standard

Project Team

The project is led by the Project Architect as Principal Designer, coordinating consultants, planning, and detailed design in response to Aberdeen’s harbour setting, climate, and industrial heritage. Planning, Civil, Structural, M&E, and Sustainability consultants support planning approval, site infrastructure, long-span structures, low-energy services, and district heat integration suited to exposed coastal conditions. Specialist consultants address acoustics, fire safety, lighting, landscape, and interpretation, ensuring compliant, well-controlled gallery and studio environments and a blue-green public realm. The Project Manager, Quantity Surveyor, and CDM Coordinator oversee programme, cost, procurement, and health and safety.

PROJECT ARCHITECT	Overall design lead; coordinates consultants, planning, detailed design, and site quality.
PLANNING CONSULTANT	Advises on planning policy, submissions, and liaison with Aberdeen City Council.
CIVIL ENGINEER	Designs drainage, SuDS, groundworks, and site infrastructure connections.
STRUCTURAL ENGINEER	Develops structural system, long spans, and load-bearing strategy.
M&E ENGINEER	Designs low-energy services, environmental control, and district heat network integration.
SUSTAINABILITY / ENVIRONMENTAL CONSULTANT	Coordinates Passivhaus alignment, carbon reduction, and blue-green infrastructure strategy.
ACOUSTIC CONSULTANT	Ensures suitable acoustic conditions between galleries, studios, and public spaces.
LANDSCAPE ARCHITECT	Designs public realm, pocket parks, and biodiversity-led blue-green infrastructure.
PROJECT MANAGER	Oversees programme, procurement, and delivery within budget and timeframe.
CDM COORDINATOR / PRINCIPAL DESIGNER	Manages health and safety risk during the design stage under CDM Regulations.
QUANTITY SURVEYOR	Provides cost planning, value engineering, and whole-life cost advice.
FIRE CONSULTANT	Develops fire strategy and escape design in line with Scottish Building Standards.
LIGHTING DESIGNER	Designs exhibition and architectural lighting to balance conservation and experience.
INTERPRETATION DESIGNER	Shapes visitor experience, storytelling, and exhibition interpretation.

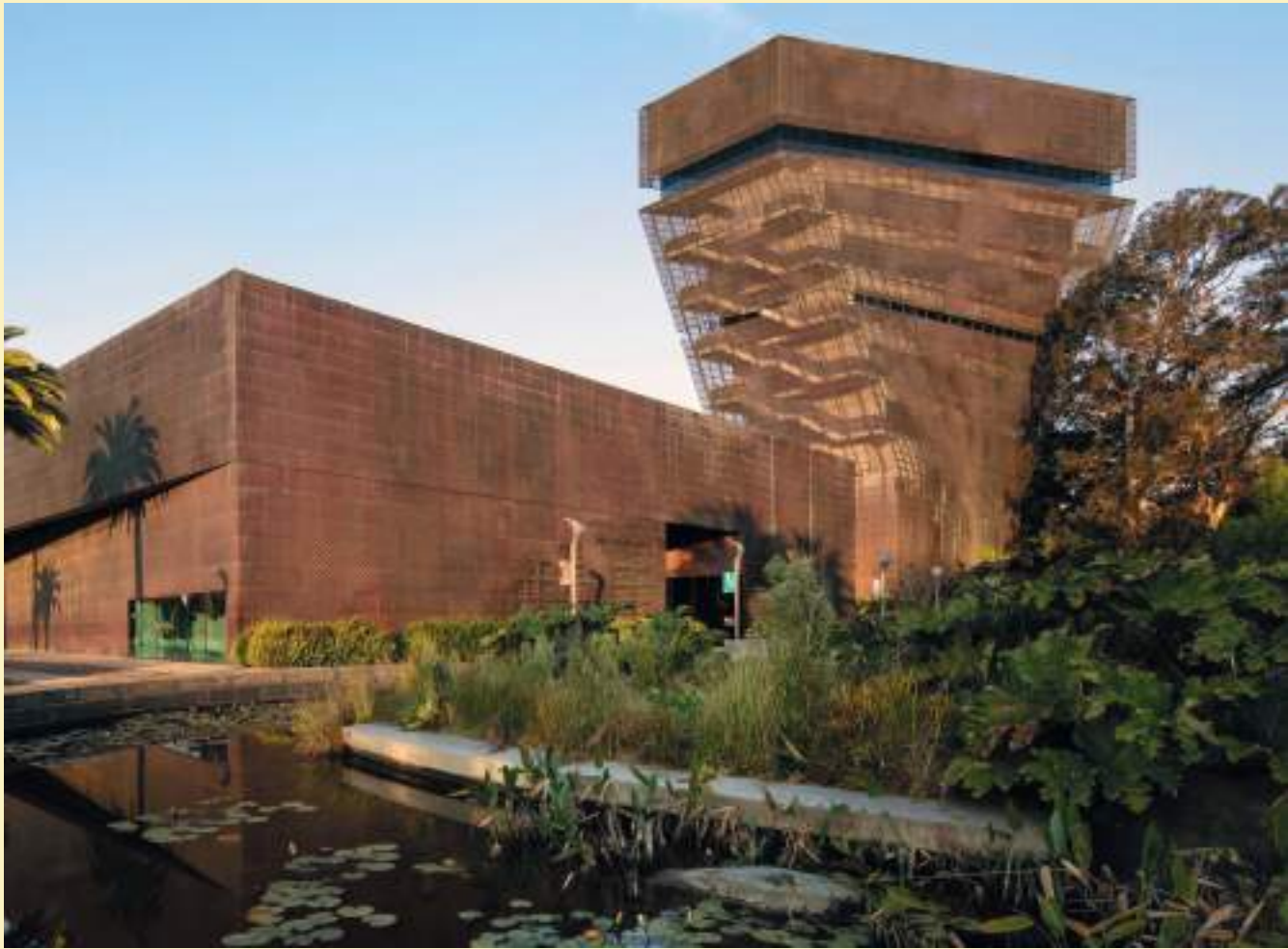
Programme



Phase 1 of Masterplan: Decommissioning
Phase 2 of Masterplan: Infrastructure



4.0 Precedents



Project name: M.H. de Young Museum
Architect: Herzog & de Meuron (with Fong + Chan Architects)
Location: Golden Gate Park, San Francisco, California, USA
Construction / completion: Built 2001-2005, completed in 2005

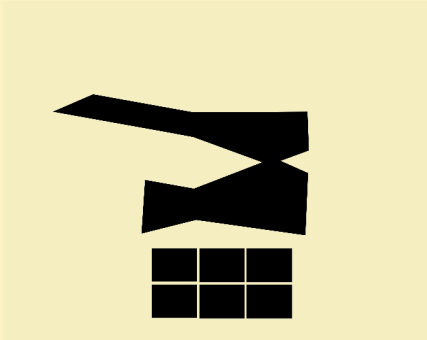
The M.H. de Young Museum is a major cultural landmark in Golden Gate Park, San Francisco, designed by Herzog & de Meuron in collaboration with Fong + Chan Architects. The current building replaced earlier museum structures damaged by earthquakes. The museum is composed of two main elements: a low, horizontal gallery building integrated into the park and the vertically expressive Hamon Tower, which offers panoramic views of the city. Public programmes are concentrated at ground level to enhance accessibility. Its perforated copper façade oxidises over time, allowing the building to visually blend with its surroundings while filtering daylight into the galleries, reinforcing a strong dialogue between architecture, landscape, and materiality.



Greenery



Inside the courtyard



Different Gallery Environments

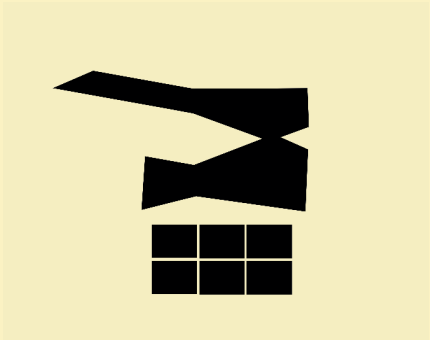
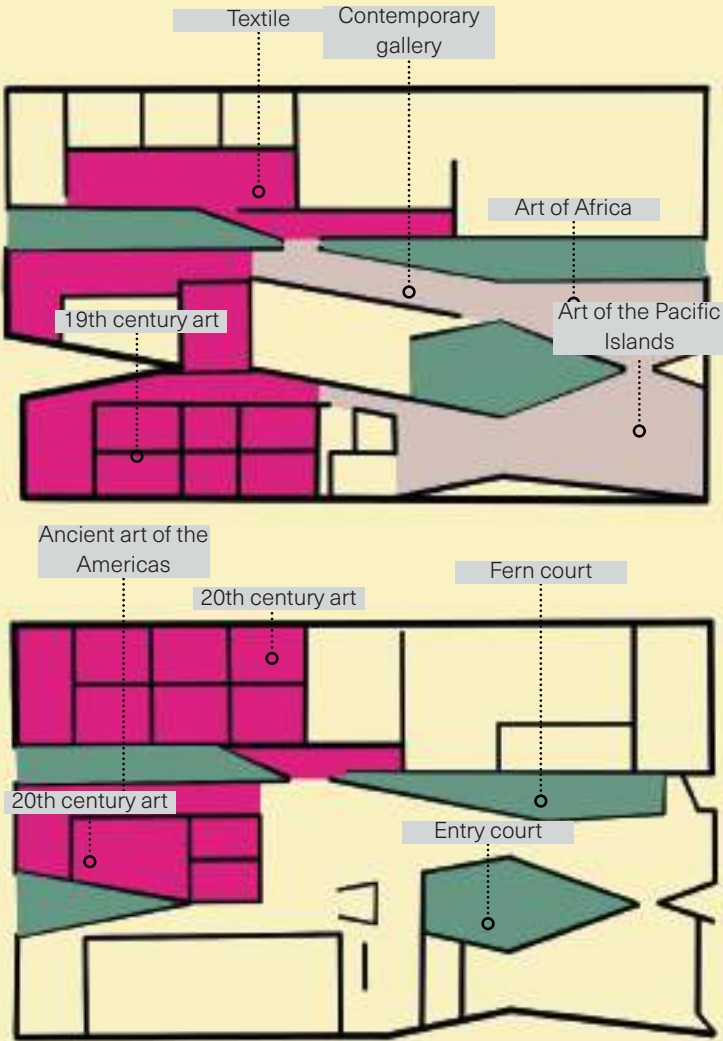


Bringing the Greenery in
At the de Young Museum, landscape is used as an integral part of the architecture. Planted courtyards cut into the building, allowing greenery, light, and views from Golden Gate Park to penetrate deep into the interior and accompany circulation routes. This strategy softens the scale of the museum, blurs the boundary between inside and outside, and reinforces a continuous relationship between art, architecture, and landscape.



Inside the Courtyard

The courtyards are planted with dense vegetation, including eucalyptus, allowing Golden Gate Park to penetrate deep into the building and visually anchor interior circulation to nature (see previous page). They bring daylight and controlled views into galleries, staircases, and public routes, helping visitors orient themselves without relying on a linear museum sequence. Several key vertical circulation elements, such as major stairs, are placed adjacent to courtyards, turning movement through the building into a spatial and sensory experience.



Different gallery environments

The de Young Museum creates different gallery environments by varying spatial proportion, enclosure, and lighting according to the cultural context of the artworks. Western collections are displayed in classically proportioned, daylit galleries, while non-Western works are housed in more flexible, inward-looking spaces with controlled artificial lighting. These contrasting gallery types are connected through courtyards and circulation spaces, allowing visitors to experience cultural diversity spatially rather than through a single, uniform museum environment.



Project name: Louisiana Museum of Modern Art
Architect: Jørgen Bo and Vilhelm Wohlert
Location: Humlebæk, Denmark
Construction / completion: 1958-1991 (phased development)

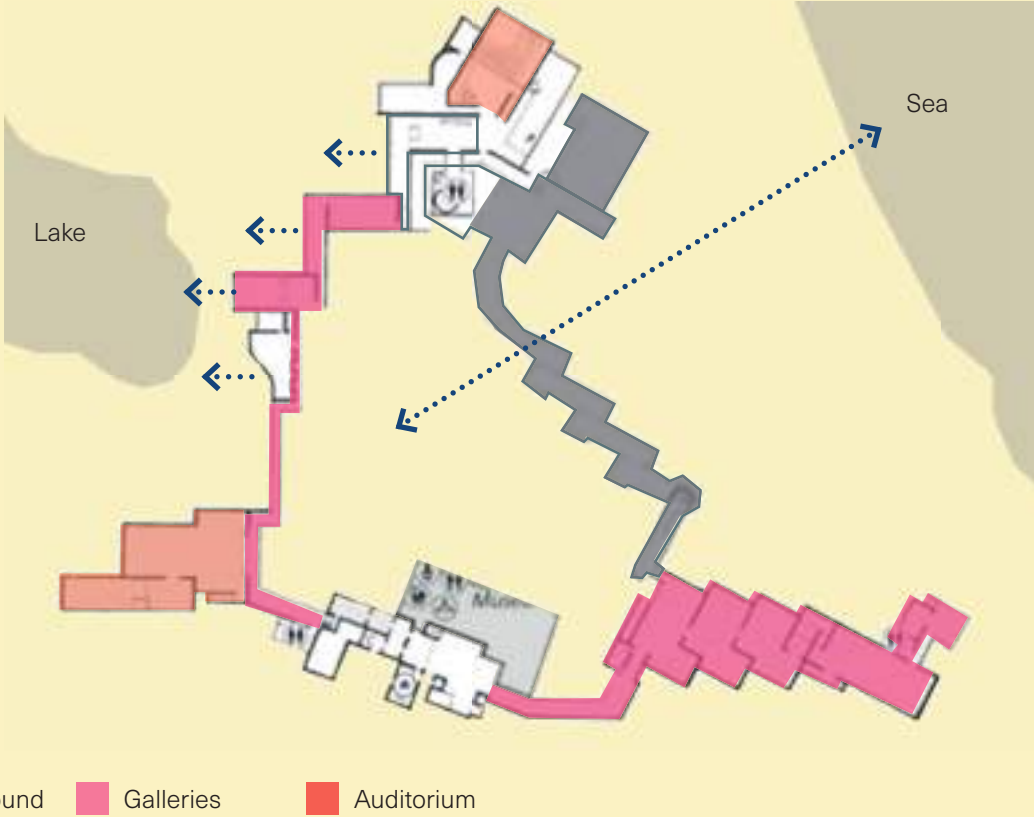
Located half an hour north of Copenhagen in the coastal village of Humlebæk, the Louisiana Museum of Modern Art is one of the world's most influential modern art institutions. Founded in the 1950s by Knud W. Jensen, the museum was designed by architects Jørgen Bo and Vilhelm Wohlert as an extension of an existing 19th-century villa, with the aim of closely linking art, architecture, and landscape. The museum is composed of a series of low modernist pavilions connected by glazed corridors and set within a sculpture park overlooking the Øresund strait. Circulation is informal and non-linear, allowing visitors to move freely between indoor galleries and outdoor spaces.



Circulation



Landscape as an extension of the building



Circulation
Instead of one dominant building, the museum is composed of low, pavilion-like volumes connected by glazed corridors that weave through gardens, and the coastal terrain overlooking the Øresund.
The museum's horizontal scale and modest height allow it to sit quietly within the landscape, maintaining the primacy of trees, topography, and the sea. Architecture follows the contours of the site, creating a sequence of interior and exterior rooms rather than a clear boundary between building and landscape. The building does not prescribe a single path, the circulation allows for multiple routes and informal detours.





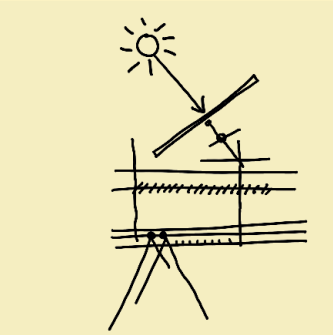
Landscape as an extension of the building

Landscape is treated as an extension of the museum experience. The sculpture park, courtyards, and coastal edge function as open-air galleries, while long glazed corridors continuously frame views of water, sky, and vegetation. Movement through the museum resembles a walk through the landscape, with alternating moments of enclosure and openness that heighten awareness of nature.

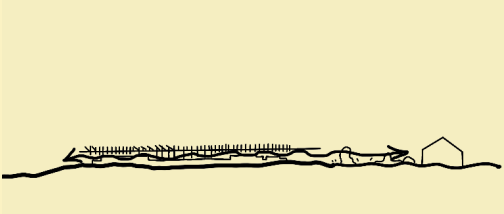


Project name: Beyeler Foundation Museum
Architects: Renzo Piano Building Workshop
Location: Riehen, Switzerland
Construction / completion: 1992-1997

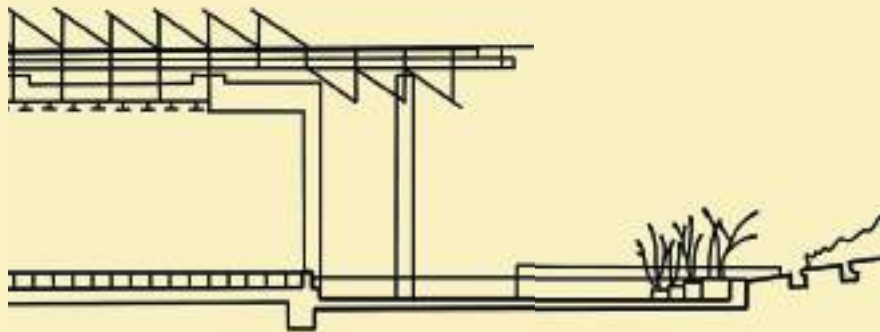
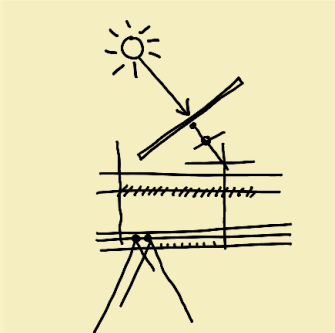
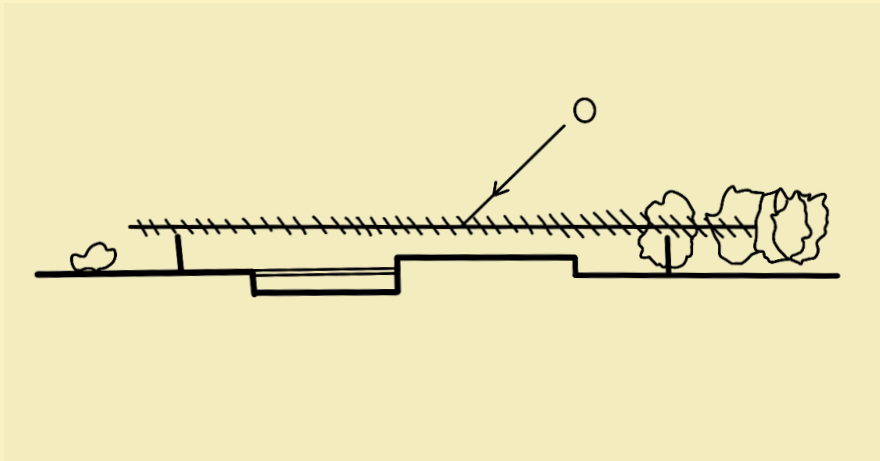
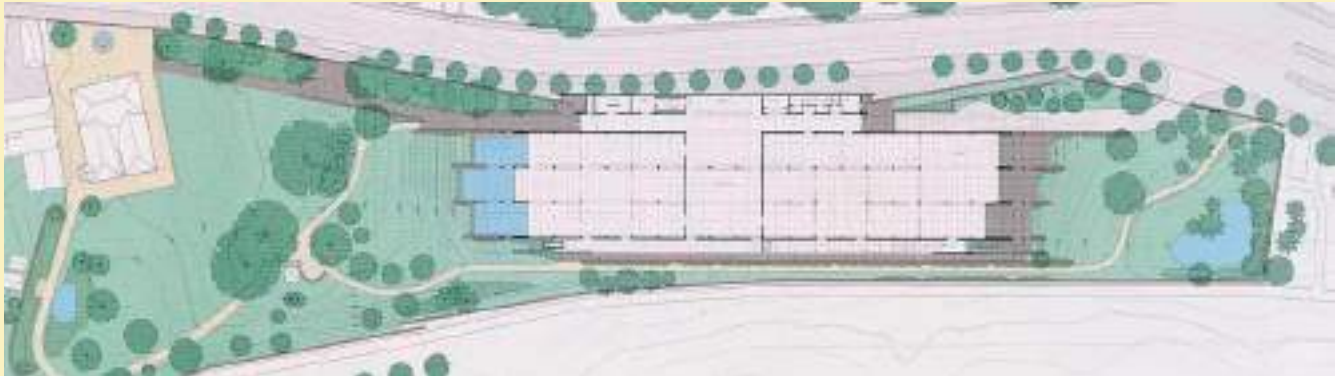
Renzo Piano's Fondation Beyeler is conceived as a calm, understated museum that prioritises art, light, and landscape over architectural spectacle. Set within a park near Basel, the building is defined by the contrast between long stone walls and a lightweight glass roof that allows natural, changing daylight into the galleries. The museum is organised as a sequence of well-proportioned rooms that balance fluid movement with moments of pause. Walls act as mediating elements rather than barriers, connecting interior and exterior space and reinforcing a quiet, contemplative relationship between architecture, artwork, and landscape.



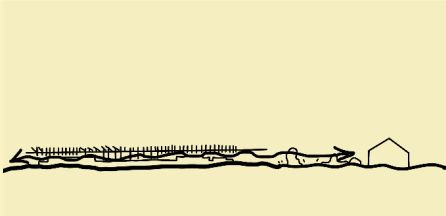
Daylight



Building and the Landscape



Daylight
At the Beyeler Museum, the building is oriented along an east-west axis so that the galleries receive predominantly north-facing, diffuse daylight, ideal for displaying art. The roof follows this alignment, using a linear skylight system and layered glazing to admit soft light while shielding the interiors from direct sun. This orientation ensures consistent lighting conditions and reinforces the museum's calm relationship with its landscape and climate.



Building and the Landscape
At the Beyeler Museum, the subtle level changes and soft spatial sequences reinforce the building's relationship with nature. Movement through the museum echoes the gentle undulations of the surrounding park, allowing the building to feel shaped by the landscape rather than imposed upon it. As visitors progress through slight rises and falls, views to gardens, water, and trees are gradually revealed and re-framed, maintaining constant visual contact with the outdoors. This slow, layered transition blurs the boundary between inside and outside, positioning the museum as a continuation of the landscape and embedding the experience of art within its natural setting.

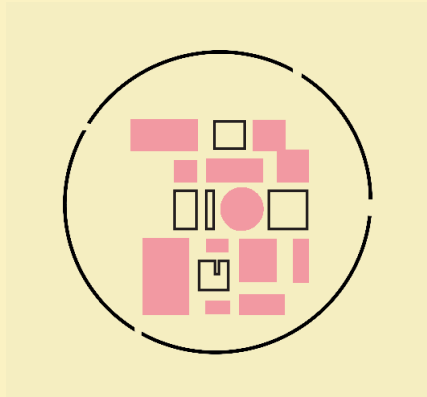
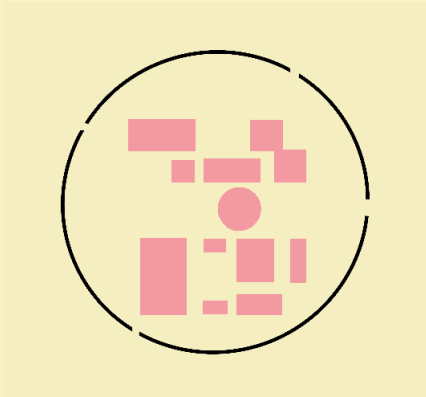
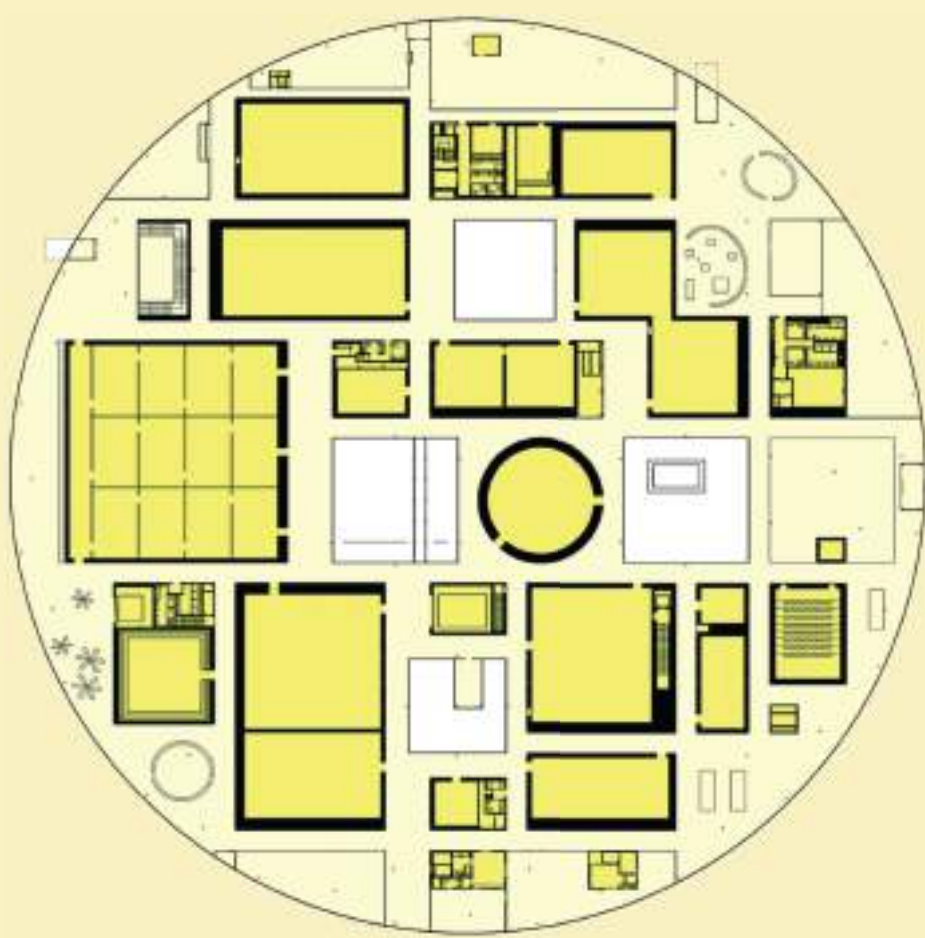


Project name: 21st Century Museum of Contemporary Art
Architects: SANAA (Kazuyo Sejima + Ryue Nishizawa)
Location: Kanazawa, Ishikawa Prefecture, Japan
Construction / completion: 2000-2004, completed in 2004

The 21st Century Museum of Contemporary Art, Kanazawa explores transparency, accessibility, and the blurring of public and private space. The low, circular form allows entry from all sides and rejects a fixed sequence of galleries, encouraging visitors to define their own routes through the building. Exhibition spaces are organised as independent volumes within a continuous glazed perimeter, interwoven with courtyards and public circulation. Extensive use of daylight, lightweight structure, and visual permeability position the museum as an open, civic cultural space embedded within the city.



Public vs Private



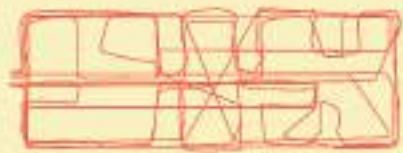
Public vs Private
At the 21st Century Museum of Contemporary Art, Kanazawa, SANAA deliberately blurs the boundary between public and private space rather than enforcing a strict separation. Public circulation, galleries, cafés, and courtyards are distributed evenly within the circular plan, allowing visitors to move freely and intuitively without passing through hierarchical thresholds. More private functions such as offices, storage, and back-of-house spaces are embedded discreetly within the grid of volumes and buffered by circulation and courtyards.

Support Courtyard Galleries Paid zone Miscellaneous

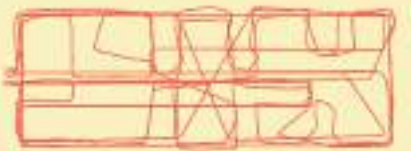
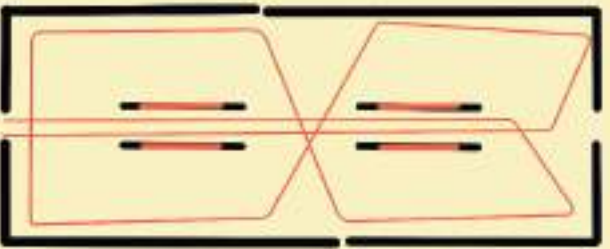
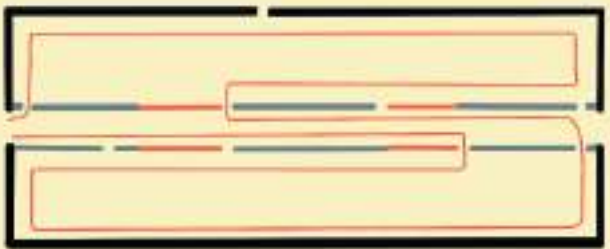
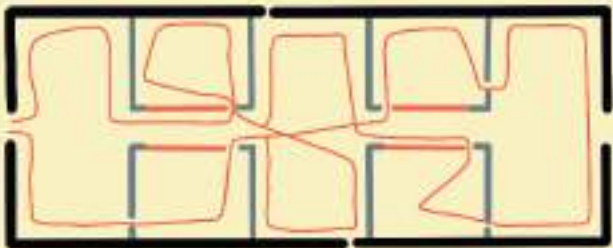
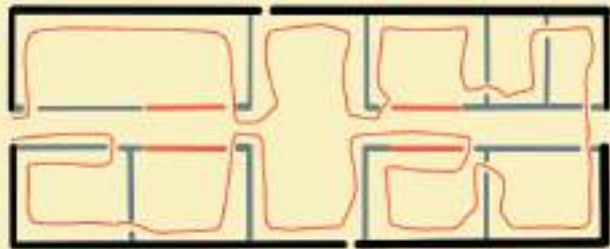
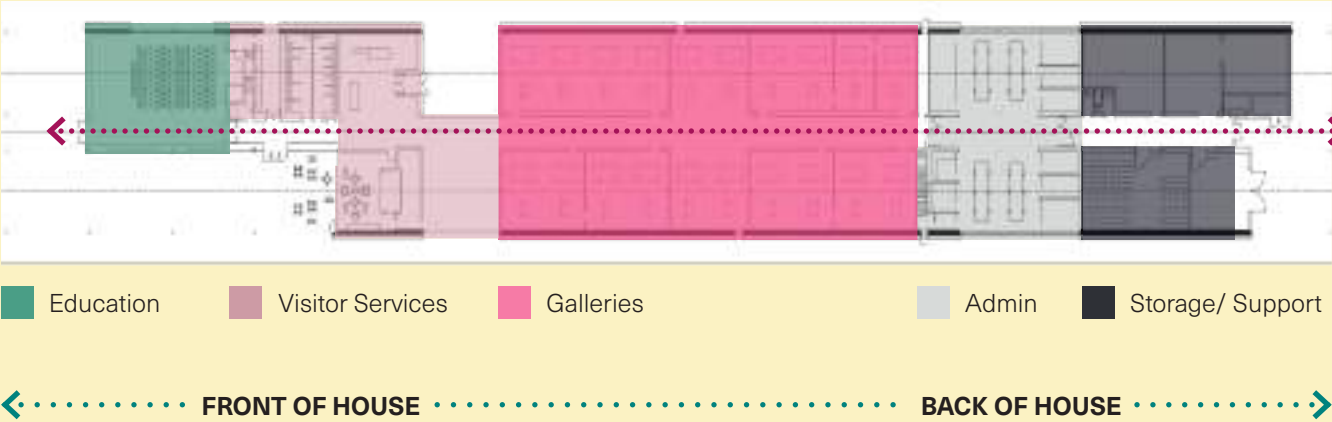


Project name: Parrish Art Museum
Architect: Herzog & de Meuron
Location: Water Mill, Long Island, New York, USA
Construction / completion: Built 2008-2012, completed in 2012

The design of the new Parrish Art Museum draws on the proportions of the local artist's studio. A repeated gallery module with north-facing skylights forms two wings around a central circulation spine, creating a clear and legible layout. Flexible galleries sit at the centre of the plan, with back-of-house functions to the east and public programmes including the lobby, shop, café, and education spaces to the west. A simple post-and-beam structure defines the building's spine. Oriented east-west to maximise north light, the museum is set within a meadow of native grasses, reinforcing its relationship to the surrounding Long Island landscape.



Movement



Movement
Visitors enter into a long central circulation spine that runs the full length of the building, functioning as both a gallery route and an orienting device. From this spine, individual galleries branch off to either side, allowing visitors to move freely between spaces without being forced into a prescribed sequence. The clear organisation makes it easy to pause, retrace steps, or skip galleries, supporting a self-directed experience. The Parrish Art Museum uses movable partition walls within a regular structural grid, allowing gallery layouts and circulation routes to be reconfigured for different exhibitions over time.



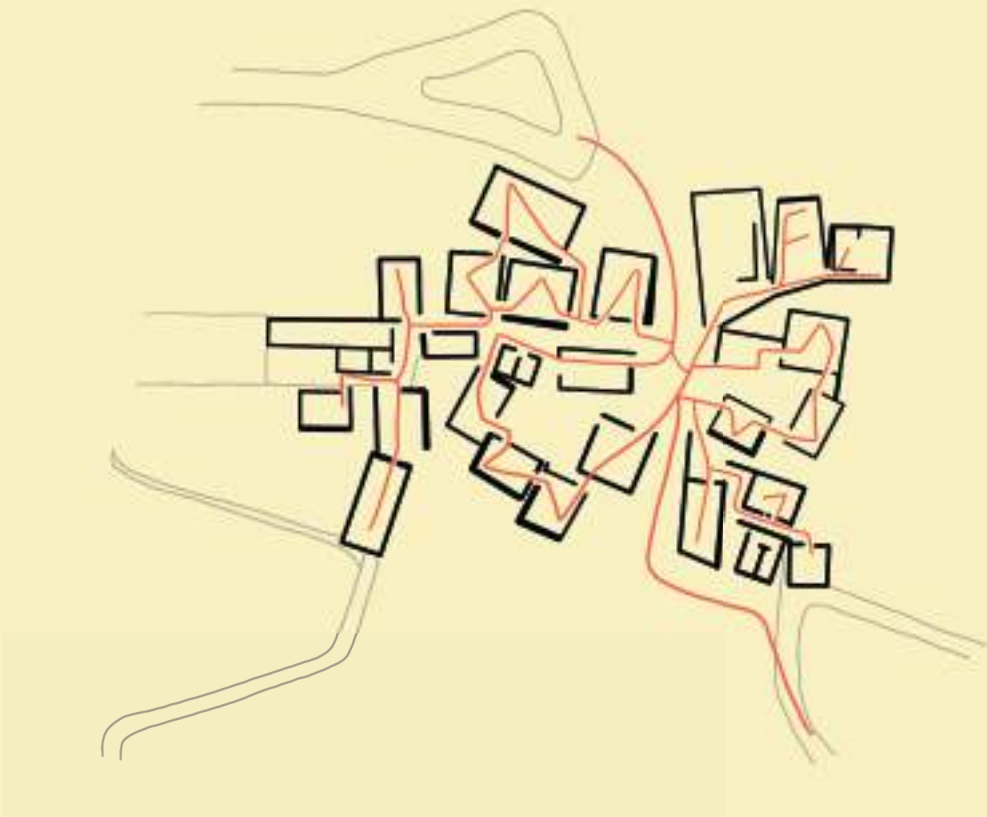
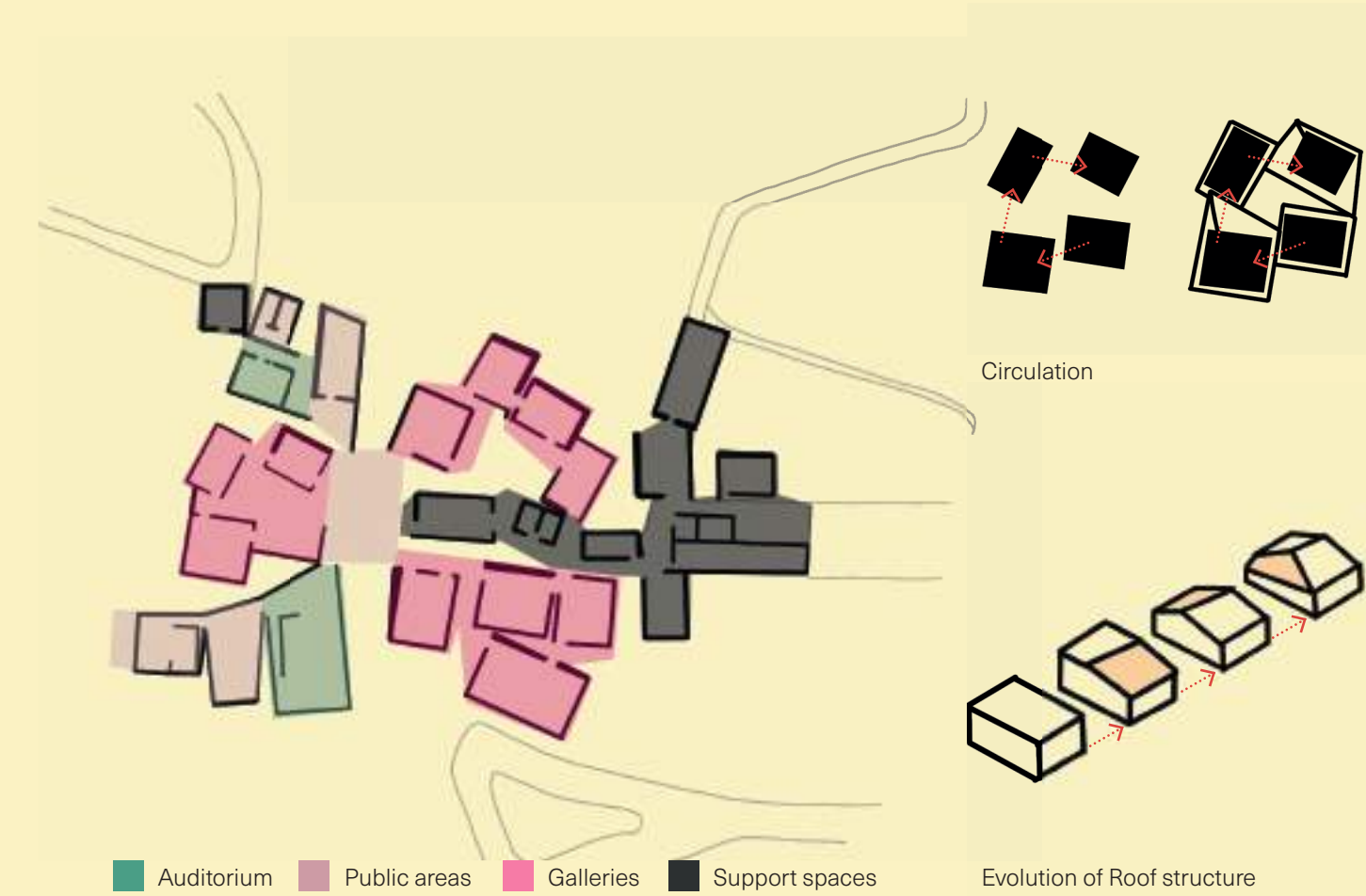
Project name: Parrish Art Museum (proposal)

Architect: Herzog & de Meuron
Location: Water Mill, Long Island, New York, USA

Herzog & de Meuron proposed a cluster of separate, barn-like pavilions spread across the rural Water Mill site. Each pavilion functioned as an independent gallery, inspired by the artists' studios of the Hamptons (such as those of Fairfield Porter, Roy Lichtenstein, and Willem de Kooning). The idea was that different buildings would offer distinct spatial qualities and lighting conditions, mainly using north-facing skylights. Instead of a linear circulation route, visitors would move freely between buildings through the landscape, choosing their own paths. This made the museum feel informal, domestic, and closely connected to the surrounding farmland, blurring the boundary between architecture, landscape, and artistic production.



Movement



Movement
The design process for the original Parrish Art Museum was rooted in an abstract study of the artist's studio as a spatial and working model. Herzog & de Meuron developed the building through extensive physical modelling, testing variations of proportion, light, and repetition to translate the studio's simplicity into a series of connected gallery spaces.



Westergasfabriek Park



National September 11 Memorial



Gasholder Park



Landschaftspark Duisburg-Nord

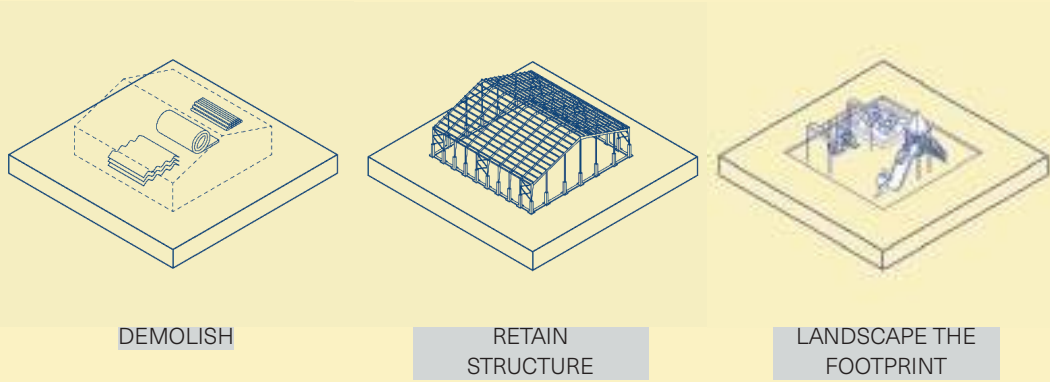
Westergasfabriek Park transforms a former gasworks into a landscape-led public park by retaining industrial structures and reshaping the contaminated ground through landform modelling and ecological remediation. Former gas tanks are reinterpreted as ponds, gardens, and event spaces, demonstrating how industrial infrastructure can be absorbed into landscape rather than removed.

National September 11 Memorial reuses the footprints of the former World Trade Center towers as sunken voids filled with water, transforming sites of destruction into spaces of reflection. Rather than reconstructing what was lost, absence itself becomes the landscape strategy, using water, depth, and sound to mark memory and structure public space.

In **Gasholder Park** in King's Cross, the historic cast-iron gas holder frames are retained to define a circular public park and surrounding development. Industrial heritage remains legible as new landscape and architecture are inserted within the original structure rather than replacing it.

In **Landschaftspark Duisburg-Nord** industrial structures such as tanks, furnaces, and pipes are retained and integrated into the landscape as gardens, climbing structures, and water features. Rather than erasing industry, the project allows it to be overtaken by nature, turning infrastructure into inhabitable landscape.

KEY STRATEGIES TO DEAL WITH INDUSTRIAL HERITAGE:



Turner Contemporary



Hepworth Wakefield Museum



Kunsthau Bregenz



Turner Contemporary (Interior)



Hepworth Wakefield Museum (Interior)

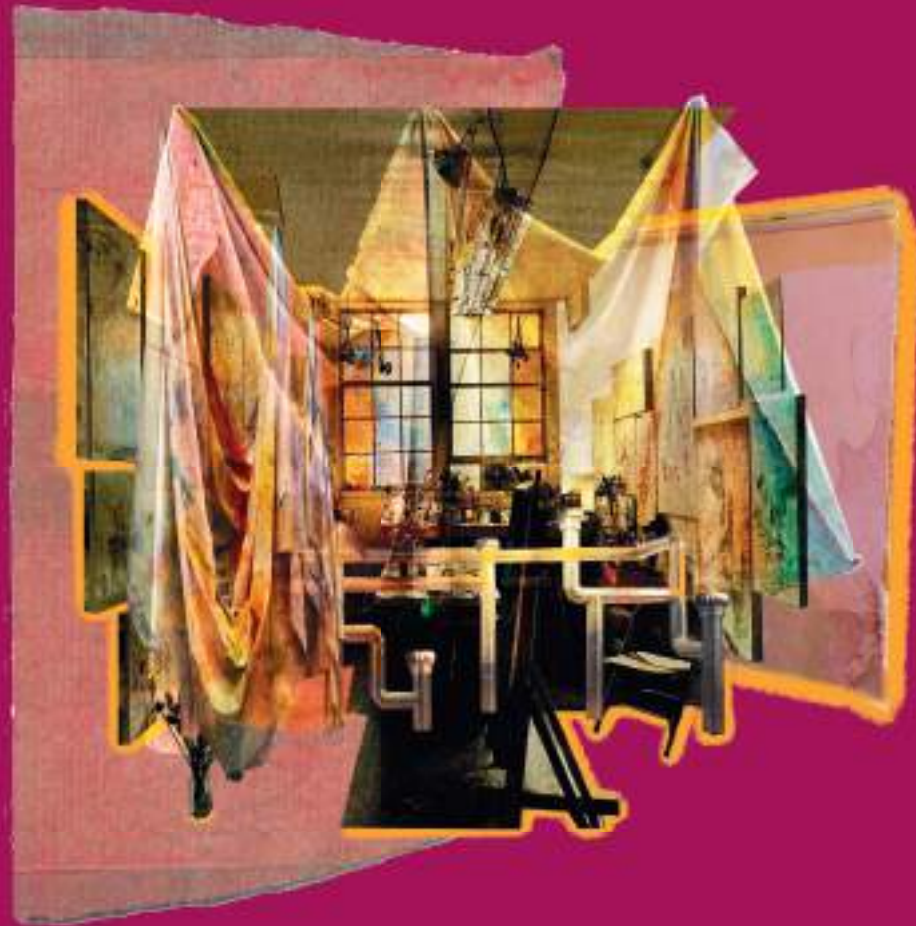


Kunsthau Bregenz (Interior)

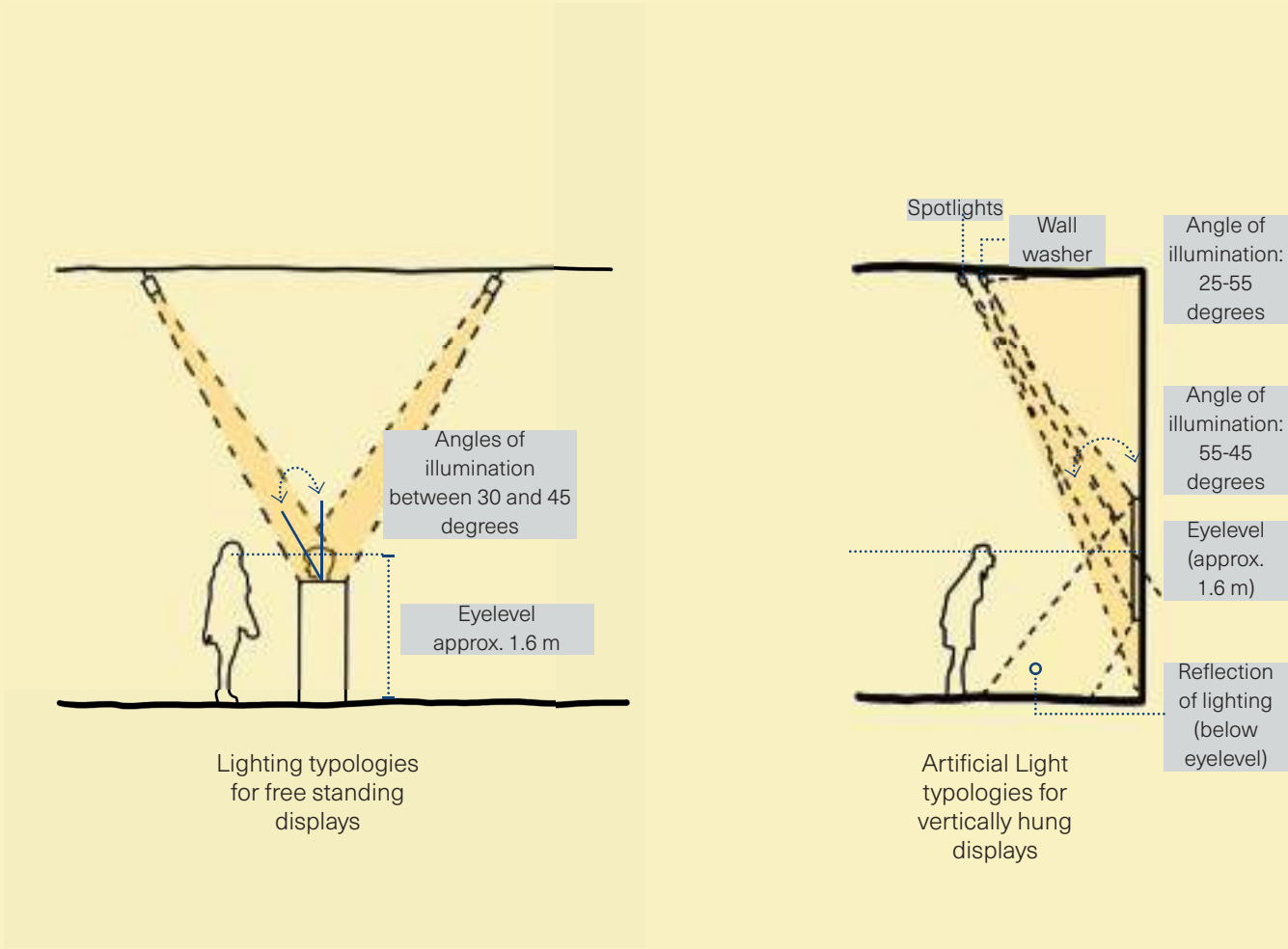
Located directly on the seafront, **Turner Contemporary** responds to the water primarily through light rather than views. North-facing rooflights capture the diffuse, reflective coastal light, allowing the sea to shape the atmosphere of the galleries while maintaining controlled, inward-looking exhibition spaces.

The Hepworth Wakefield sits within the River Calder, using water as a structural and spatial condition rather than a backdrop. The building is raised above the river level, with solid concrete volumes and carefully placed openings that frame water views while protecting galleries from flooding.

Kunsthau Bregenz engages Lake Constance indirectly by using the reflected and misted light from the water to illuminate its galleries. The etched glass façade absorbs and filters changing lake light, allowing water to influence the interior atmosphere without direct visual connection.



5.0 Design Approach and Considerations

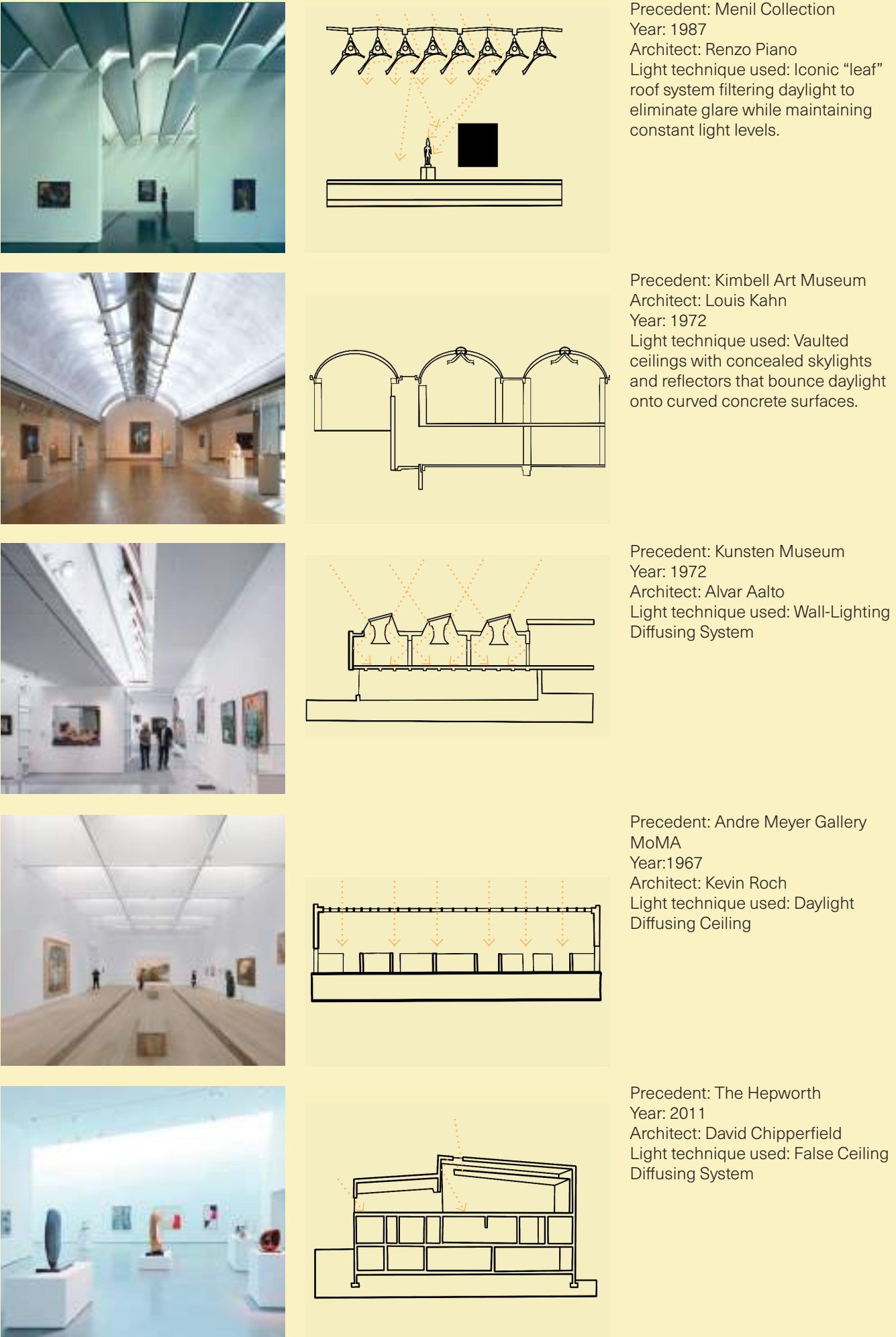


Lighting is central to both the experience and conservation of artworks. While it reveals colour and texture, excessive exposure can cause long-term damage to sensitive materials. This project will adopt a controlled lighting strategy that balances atmosphere and preservation through limited light levels, reduced exposure time, and the minimisation of ultraviolet and infrared radiation, creating a calm, domestic environment that supports exhibition, making, and public engagement.

Key Rules:

- Avoid direct sunlight at all times
- Limit light levels according to artwork sensitivity
- Control exposure time to reduce cumulative damage
- Minimise ultraviolet and infrared radiation
- Use high-quality LED lighting (CRI ≥ 90)
- Manage glare through careful fitting position and shielding
- Balance accent and ambient light to guide attention
- Combine daylight and artificial light in a controlled way

ARTWORK	ARTWORK SENSITIVITY	MAX LUX	MAX ANNUAL EXPOSURE
Paper, textiles, photos	Very sensitive	50 lux	15,000-100,000 lux hrs
Paintings, wood	Moderately sensitive	200 lux	≤ 450,000 lux hrs
Stone, metal, glass	Low sensitivity	300 lux	No strict limit





Accessible toilets including a changing places facility with a bed.



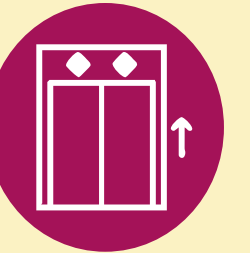
We can provide a wheelchair for you to borrow. All of our spaces are wheelchair accessible.



Portable folding stools are available for visitors to borrow.



Communication cards are available by reception and online to ask for help or directions.



Step free (street-level) access and lifts.



Hearing loops are fitted at our reception desk and at the exhibition space.



Children's and adult's ear defenders are available at reception.



Easy Read and Large Print exhibition guides are available in the galleries, at our reception desk and online.

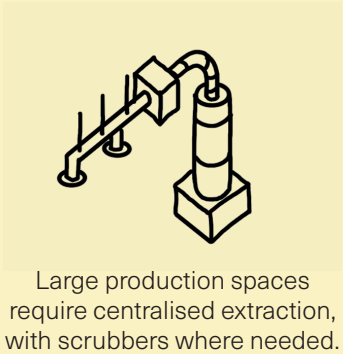
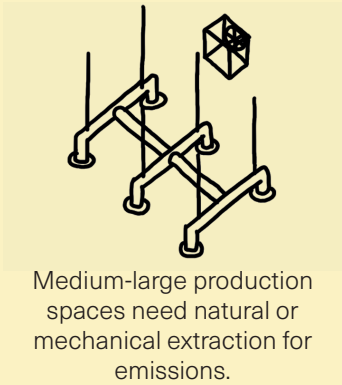
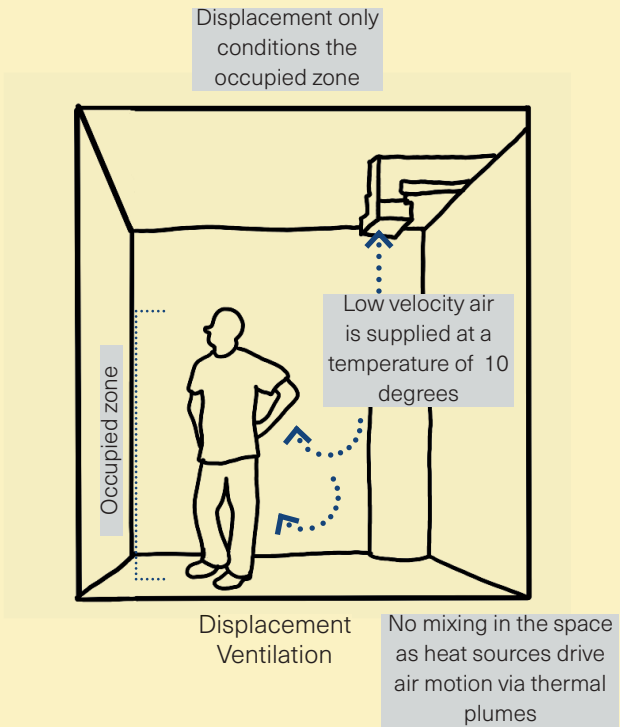
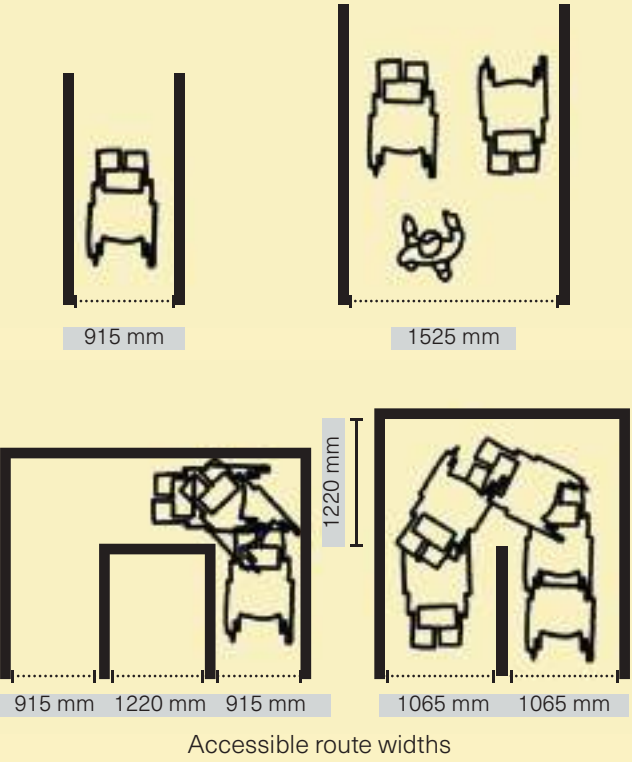
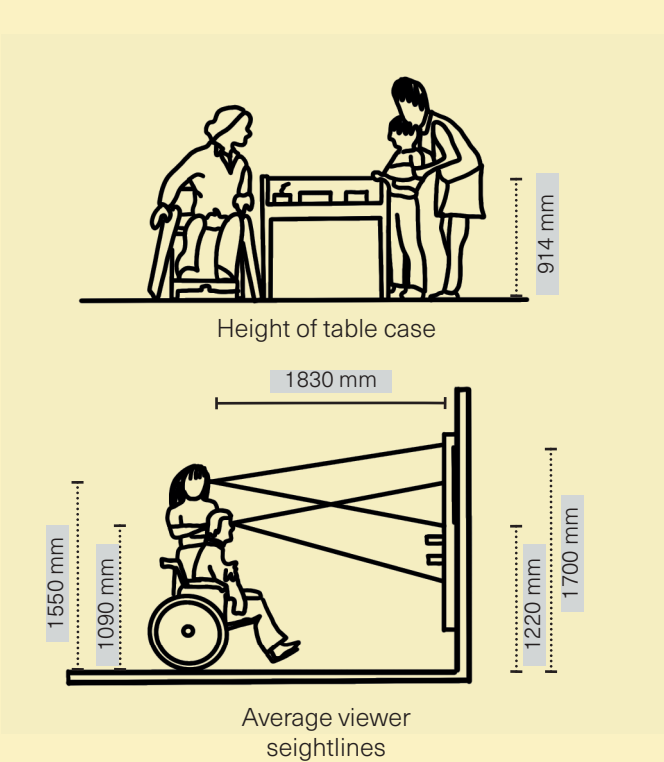


Audio Description guides to some artworks are available online and at our reception desk.



Coloured overlays and magnifiers are available at our reception desk.

Accessibility is a fundamental aspect of architectural design and must be considered throughout the development of a project. The images above are taken from the Newcastle Contemporary and illustrate inclusive design strategies that inform this approach. This page responds specifically to Section 4 (Safety) of the Scottish Building Regulations, which addresses accessibility and inclusive access for all users. By embedding these principles within the spatial and architectural design, the gallery is positioned as a welcoming and equitable environment that supports use by people of all abilities.



Ventilation is a critical component in the design of gallery and studio spaces, as it directly affects both the long-term conservation of artworks and the comfort of occupants. Carefully controlled air movement, temperature and humidity are essential to prevent material degradation, while also ensuring a calm, quiet environment that does not distract from the experience of the space. As a result, ventilation strategies in cultural buildings must balance technical performance with architectural sensitivity, integrating environmental control discreetly into the spatial design.

ASPECT	GALLERY SPACES	STUDIO SPACES
Ventilation type	Mechanical displacement ventilation	Primarily natural ventilation, with mechanical support
Air supply / extract	Low-level supply, high-level extract	Cross-ventilation via openings; local and high-level extract
Specialist extraction	Not typically required	Required for fumes, dust, solvents
Other considerations	Very low air velocity; Very low noise	More flexible and variable

Interview

This interview was conducted with Valerie Tsang, a curator with professional experience in commercial gallery environments. It explores key curatorial and spatial considerations for contemporary galleries, including the relationship between exhibition and studio spaces, lighting, branding, layout, and operational requirements. The interview has been edited for clarity and is presented as a curated extract to inform the development of the project brief.

Question: What level of separation is typically needed between working spaces and public gallery spaces?

Answer: Artists need a private personal space. You don't want customers walking around their canvases or into their working area while they are producing work. Artists are often very particular and have unique working habits, so giving them freedom and separation is important. Studios and galleries should be clearly distinct spaces.

Question: How important is natural lighting in galleries and studios?

Answer: Natural lighting is very important, especially for two-dimensional work and sculpture. It is important not only for artists but also for sales, because it shows clients how colours really look and how the artwork would appear in their own space. Artificial lighting on its own is usually frowned upon.

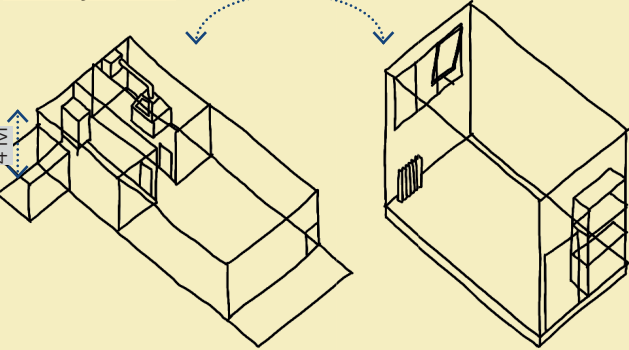
Question: What is the main purpose of a gallery, and how should that affect design?

Answer: Unless the gallery is a charity, the main purpose is selling artwork. The storefront needs to be as attractive as possible, because most people have seen many galleries in their life and they often all look the same with white walls. Galleries can feel intimidating or like spaces only rich people enter, so the design needs to be welcoming while still maintaining a luxury, high-end feel. It is a difficult balance.



Question: What makes a gallery space feel more successful and comfortable?

Answer: High ceilings make a space feel more luxurious and comfortable. They reduce the feeling of pressure and claustrophobia and allow people to feel free to browse without being pushed into buying. Large glazed windows are important so people can see inside. Colours should be muted and neutral so they do not compete with the artwork, but the space should not be boring or entirely white.



Individual studios of provide secure, naturally lit and ventilated workspace, with heating via wet systems or space heaters.

Question: What back-of-house spaces are critical for a gallery to function well?

Answer: Storage is essential, and ideally there should be two separate storage spaces. One should be for artworks and designed carefully in terms of temperature, humidity, and lighting. The other can be for practical items such as chairs, tables, glassware, and equipment used for openings, talks, and events. These spaces should be hidden from public view.

Question: What kind of space is needed for sales and client discussions?

Answer: A gallery needs more than just a front desk or cashier point. There should be a comfortable and high-quality space where discussions with clients can take place. This could be a seating area or a place to serve drinks. It should feel slightly private but still be visually connected to the artworks, rather than a completely closed room.



Question: How should public or free galleries be spatially organised?

Answer: Wide spaces are preferable. Narrow spaces limit how artworks can be displayed and how people move through the gallery. Wider spaces allow artworks on both walls and sometimes in the middle, such as sculptures. This also allows more people to view artworks at the same time and makes the space feel more flexible.

Question: How important is flexibility in lighting design?

Answer: Lighting needs to be flexible. Fixed lighting is a problem because different artworks have different requirements. Diffuse lighting is preferable, as it can be adjusted to be more focused if needed, whereas the opposite is not possible. Poor lighting and unwanted shadows are one of the biggest mistakes galleries make.

Question: Are movable walls a good strategy for flexibility?

Answer: Movable walls can work in very small spaces, but in larger galleries they are often avoided. They are not very stable and over time they degrade because of repeated drilling and installation. For long-term durability and sustainability, permanent walls are generally better, with movable elements kept only as a backup.

Question: What is the difference between commercial galleries and national or public galleries?

Answer: National galleries focus more on culture and viewing rather than sales. Exhibitions often stay for a long time and entry is usually free. The design focuses on experience, lighting, and atmosphere. Commercial galleries are more like retail spaces, where the layout and sequence are designed to encourage engagement and purchasing.

Question: How are artworks usually curated and sequenced in a commercial gallery?

Answer: Commercial galleries do not usually arrange artworks chronologically. Instead, they are arranged by material, colour, and visual relationship to make the space look cohesive. More visually striking works are often placed at the front or back to draw people through the gallery, with secondary works in between.

Question: What common design mistakes should be avoided?

Answer: Common mistakes include inflexible lighting, unsafe placement of sculptures near circulation routes, and accidentally blocking artworks with poorly positioned walls. If artworks are visually blocked, it should be done intentionally and for a clear curatorial reason, not by accident.

Question: Should galleries encourage visitors to stay longer?

Answer: Yes. Events such as talks, workshops, and artist-led activities help make galleries feel more inclusive and welcoming. These elements prevent galleries from feeling like spaces only for wealthy buyers and help engage a wider public.

Question: How should interaction with artworks be handled?

Answer: Interaction should always be decided by the artist. If touching is not allowed, subtle measures such as low wires or sensors are preferable to visible barriers. If interaction is encouraged, clear signage or demonstrations should be used so visitors feel comfortable engaging.

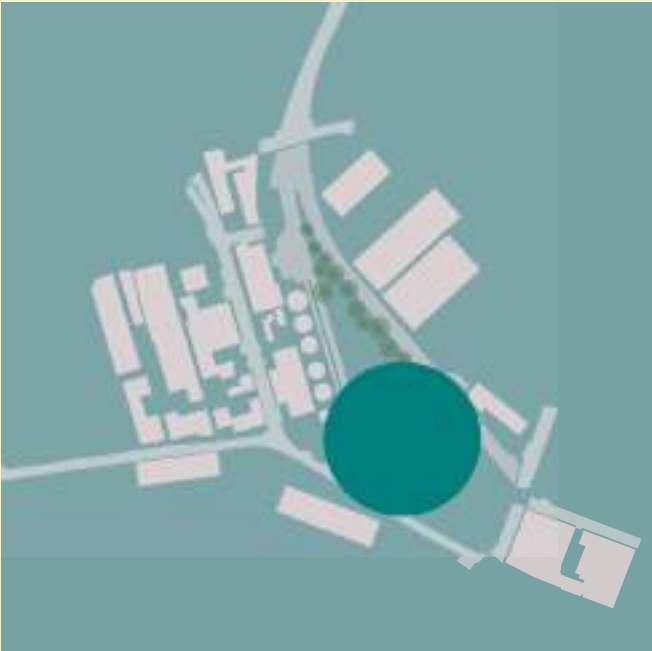
Question: How should performance art be accommodated?

Answer: Performance art is usually planned and invitation-based. It should not take place directly at the entrance. Instead, people gather in one space and are then guided into the performance area. Separation between performer and audience is usually achieved through lighting or seating rather than physical barriers.

Applying the Precedents



Courtyards penetrate the building, drawing light and landscape into the interior and strengthening visual connections. The building is oriented toward Deemouth Artists Studios, with a large forecourt forming a ceremonial entrance sequence. Studio spaces are located in the north-east corner to maximise natural light, while a taller tower element in the north-west responds to the site's industrial heritage.



Circulation is intentionally unprescribed, with gallery spaces located centrally and naturally lit through rooflights and courtyards. Support spaces are arranged around the perimeter of the building, reinforcing a clear spatial hierarchy.



Light has informed both the placement of creative spaces and the organisation of circulation within the building. Creative spaces are located along the northern edge of the site to benefit from consistent daylight, while a central corridor or axis penetrates the building to structure movement and spatial clarity.



Circulation within the building is organised as a continuous loop, with spaces opening onto a central courtyard. Some functions may be located at basement level to support efficient circulation while maintaining optimal daylight levels within the main gallery spaces.

